down to the wire

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31098638.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Other Minor Characters

Additional Tags:
melog is a horse in this fic, best friends to kind of enemies to workplace associates to lovers, this is a horse racing au, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Hurt/Comfort, Angst, veterinarian adora, horse trainer catra, alternating pov, some flashbacks to catra and adora's college days, Mild Smut

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by ehj

Summary

often times, in the qiet of the morning, when the fog is still settled over the track and everyone sleepily lumbers around the barn with the horses, it reminds her of those early saturday mornings in the foaling barn when she was eighteen. often times, in the qiet of the morning, when the fog is still settled over the track, she thinks of adora.

or: catra and adora's horse girl summer.

or: pov your intense homoerotic friendship that ended abruptly comes roaring back when it turns out she's the track vet for the biggest race of the year.

backstretch

Chapter Notes

WELCOME to the infamous horse girl summer, my big bang fic. this is one of the first au ideas i came up with after i watched she-ra and it is heavily influenced by my time working on large thoroughbred farms and being involved in the horse racing industry in the past.

for big bang, i am getting to work with not one but TWO lovely artists: follow them both on twitter @blackcleryberry_ and @sunflowerpau_ because their art is fabulous and i've really enjoyed getting to work with two very talented individuals!

shoutout to alex, my beloved, for getting an advanced screening of this and acting as a beta. while you're here, go read their big bang fic across the stars (i'll always find you), also known as pew pew au.

rated M for language, alcohol, and some mild smut.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

(SATURDAY SEVEN DAYS BEFORE THE DERBY)

Something Catra's always appreciated about horses is the way they see right through people.

It's a survival tactic, she knows that horses are prey animals by nature and can pick up on nonverbals better than most of the people around her.

When Catra's anxious, Melog can sense it. He holds his head a little higher, his body more rigid, his eyes wider. When Catra's angry—when she nearly falls off because he somehow dropped a stirrup

going thirty miles per hour down the track—Melog seems to pick up on that too. All the horses do.

It's a quiet, tense kind of anger right before she explodes.

And everyone can tell when it's coming—Catra's always been one to wear her heart on her sleeve, and working around animals as emotionally intuitive as the horses can be certainly doesn't help.

She usually just appreciates it when she can use it to get a better read on the people around her.

Catra's been around horses for most of her life, picking up riding at a very young age, and working all through college at Fright Zone Farms. It's been eight years since she was a college freshman just trying to get extra hours on the weekends to help care for the mares and foals on the farm, eight years since she started at Etheria University's Equine Management program with hopes to become one of the best trainers in racing. Since she met Adora and Bow, who worked with her through college.

And now, rapidly rising to becoming one of Hordak and Ms. Weaver's favorite trainers to entrust their regally-bred horses to, she's found herself conditioning one of the early favorites for the Etherian Derby.

Catra perches at her spot on the rail as Melog tears around the track, kicking up dust and extending his stride as he rounds the corner, keyed on his back and giving him just a bit more rein to take hold of. It's a beautiful thing to watch—some horses just have the innate will to work. To race. To *win.* Just like Catra.

For someone who grew up always thinking she would end up in second place, her training career has proven just the opposite, proven that she gets to be in the winners' circle, too. And even though Weaver (*Shadow* Weaver, Adora had nicknamed her, as she always seemed to be lurking in the shadows at the exact moments when Catra and Adora were goofing off) has and continues to love to

find fault in every little thing that Catra does, she knows that Weaver (and Hordak) would be hard-pressed to find someone who knows these horses as well and could train them better than Catra.

She peers through binoculars as Melog gallops down the stretch toward the finish line, and hears the click of a stopwatch next to her.

"By my calculations, Melog was 16% less efficient in today's workout than yesterday's."

This tidbit comes from Entrapta, her friend and colleague who specializes in all the maintenance of keeping Fright Zone Farms' facilities up to date. In her spare time, she's an analytics whiz, calculating and studying each horse's training and how Catra can improve their workouts.

Where Entrapta stands to her right, Catra hears a gasp from her left, and Scorpia, another trainer for the farm, speaks up.

"Is he okay? Did he not eat enough before he went out? Does he need a snack?"

Catra groans and reaches out to grab Scorpia's arm before she can disappear to grab some treats for Melog.

"Melog is fine. He's not racing for another week."

And it's true. He's fine. The horse looks fine.

And she'd rather have him peak on the first Saturday in May than a week early.

"Well, if anything is wrong, it'll come up in the vet check later," Lonnie, one of her assistants, chimes in from behind them.

"He's fine," Catra grits out, and she whirls around to head back toward the barn to meet Melog and Kyle.

The horse looks none the worse for wear when he returns—maybe just a bit more sweaty than usual, but it's been unusually warm in Bright Moon for the past week, and Catra chalks it up to that.

She rubs the horse's forehead once he's back in his stall, while Melog's nose nuzzles toward her pockets on the lookout for any spare peppermints that Catra has.

Catra smiles softly, making sure everyone else is occupied and not looking at her, and drops a kiss to the top of his head, breathing in the scent of his forelock and wrapping an arm around the middle of his long nose.

Something Catra's always appreciated about horses is the way they see right through people.

And here, in these quieter moments, Catra appreciates when Melog can see right through her, too.

She stands there for a while longer, just scratching behind Melog's ears and looking back and forth down the shed-row to glance at the other horses, watching the ones doing laps walking around the barn just to stretch their legs for the morning.

Often times, in the quiet of the morning, when the fog is still settled over the track and everyone sleepily lumbers around the barn with the horses, it reminds her of those early Saturday mornings in the foaling barn when she was eighteen. When she had just met Bow.

They don't see each other as often now, with Bow working for Bright Moon Stables and splitting his time between their Derby hopeful, Swift Wind, and his fiancée and daughter of the barn's owners, Glimmer.

But they still make time for each other, and well, that's more than Catra can say for her and Adora.

Adora, her college best friend and roommate.

Adora, who left her for vet school on the opposite coast.

Adora, who she was hopelessly in love with.

Often times, in the quiet of the morning, when the fog is still settled over the track, she thinks of Adora.

Even though she tries not to.

Even though it's been almost four years since they've been close.

Catra's getting yelled at by Weaver (again)—something about how the way she's mucking stalls isn't quite up to her standards. But Catra is barely listening, has learned to tune it out. And besides, there's someone standing behind Weaver, a new girl dressed in a tight white long-sleeve shirt that has no business clinging to her arms the way it does, muscles rippling through all the way up to her shoulders and fuck*, if this job is going to suck, at least Catra now has something nice to look at.*

Weaver finishes whatever rant she was on and then turns toward this new girl, blonde and blue-eyed and unfairly attractive.

"This is Adora. She'll be joining you and Bow on the weekends. Try not to drag her down with you, will you, Catra?"

And with that, Weaver dismisses them all, and this Adora watches until Weaver is out of eye and earshot.

"Well, she seems fun," Adora says dryly.

And then her gaze turns to Catra, and her face lights up with a smile that Catra will be thinking about for hours after they part.

"Hi, I'm Adora."

She holds out a hand for Catra to shake.

Catra meets her halfway.

“Catra.”

“Nice to meet you, Catra.”

Catra just nods and pulls her hand back, then nods in the direction that Weaver walked away.

“Sorry about her. She’s kind of…”

“A bitch? She seems like kind of a bitch,” Adora finishes for her, and Catra’s eyes go wide.

And then she’s laughing, almost doubled over in surprise at this new girl’s confidence and cockiness that should totally be annoying and a turn-off, but so far, Catra can’t seem to get enough of it.

“Besides,” Adora continues. “Someday she’ll have to retire, and then maybe it’ll be me and you calling the shots.”

And she’s hooked from the start.

Catra would quickly find out that she and Adora were in the same major, even in one of the same classes but with the large size of the lecture hall, they hadn't yet realized it just two weeks into the semester. And Bow, who Catra had met after she found him shooting arrows in the green space behind their dorm (“there’s really no other place to practice without the risk of hitting cars, Catra!” he’d explained), took to Adora just as quickly.

And so it became the three of them, working together and studying together, and then by the end of the first semester, Adora insisting that she and Catra hang out just the two of them.

By the end of freshman year, Adora had convinced Catra to move into a two-bedroom apartment just a couple blocks away from campus. It’d be the place where Catra would spend the next three years living, would spend the next three years by Adora’s side and

trying to shove away the feelings she very quickly had found growing for her.

Adora wouldn't want me, she'd quickly convinced herself. *Not like I want her.*

So Catra took what she could get in the meantime, going to parties on the weekends with Adora and getting to hear the too-loud bark of her laughter whenever she drank too much, watch the way she would strike up conversations with strangers and listen intently while she kept sipping on whatever bourbon she and Bow had brought to the party.

She'd enjoy movie nights at Bow and his roommate Seahawk's house, she and Adora huddled onto their too-small couch together.

And she'd suffer through watching Adora go on dates with other girls, though none of them ever seemed to last long.

And then, graduation.

And then Adora went to vet school.

And the memories don't really matter anymore, because they haven't spoken since. Whatever she had with Adora isn't worth fixing, and Catra's not sure it could be fixed.

Despite the fact that she and Bow (and now Glimmer) are still very close with Adora.

Despite the fact that they see each other around at racing events occasionally, never exchanging much more than a polite wave.

Despite the fact that Adora still has a hold on Catra somewhere deep, and Catra has tried her best to claw it out so many times.

It never seems to work.

So in the quiet of the morning—even though she tries not to most times—when the fog is still settled over the track, Catra lets herself think of Adora.

And then, she goes about her day, focused in on the horses and their performance, and pretends Adora doesn't exist.

It's sometime later in the afternoon, when Catra is staring at her phone and watching a race replay of one of her other horses running at Salineas Racecourse, that Scorpia calls out to her that the track vet is here to do a quick check-up on Melog.

She whirls around to see a tall woman standing in the parking lot next to the barns and another figure rummaging around in the tailgate of the vet truck.

"I'm Dr. Hope," the veterinarian greets simply, clinically, almost like she's a hologram.

She gestures behind her as the other person, rooting around in the truck and clearly knocking something over that they shouldn't (if the way the person mutters "fuck" is anything to go by when something fragile-sounding clunks against the side of the truck), finally turns around.

And Catra's stomach drops.

"And this is Dr. Grayskull. She's interning with us and will be assisting."

The other person turns around, and Catra stands face-to-face with Adora—no, *Dr. Grayskull*—who she's barely seen or spoken to in four years.

No.

No no no no no.

The same Adora, who still has muscles bulging out of her shirt, now paired with a stupid lab coat that she's tied around her waist, and blue-gray eyes that make Catra's breath stutter and—

This is *not* the time for this to be happening.

There's probably never a good time, Catra realizes.

But Derby week is the worst-case scenario.

"Adora?" is all Catra can think to say in greeting.

And Adora, who's been looking over at Melog and Scorpia, and hasn't even noticed Catra yet, turns toward the sound of Catra's voice with wide eyes.

Adora's face is probably a mirror image of Catra's, as the two just stand and stare at each other while Scorpia and D. Hope stand by silently.

Something Catra's always appreciated about horses is the way they see right through people.

Right now, she does not appreciate the way Melog starts side-stepping impatiently and blowing hot air out of his nostrils noisily like he's just as anxious as Catra is.

And then Adora finally clears her throat, takes one step toward Catra with a hand out, like she's approaching a scared animal and not—

No. She can't do this right now.

"Catra. I—"

Catra backpedals and exhales shakily.

"Scorpia, you can handle this, right? I have to go see Hordak."

"But Catra—"

Catra grabs at her own shoulder and rubs up and down her arm nervously, resisting the urge to sink her claws into her arm because maybe that would hurt less than seeing Adora again and thinking about how badly she fucked things up.

"I'll come back later. When they're gone."

She doesn't give Adora another glance.

Catra turns on her heel and walks away from Adora, not stopping until she's through the barn and locked in her office, ignoring the distressed whinny that Melog lets out as she leaves.

Just like she walked away four years ago, before she could give Adora the chance to leave her behind.

///

Adora isn't sure how four years of time spent apart can seemingly evaporate whenever she sees Catra.

They don't see each other often at all - different fancy fundraising events and occasionally at races, but even despite the two of them both still being close to Bow, they don't cross paths often.

And when they do, the conversations are short. If they even have a conversation. Usually, Catra just gives Adora a curt nod, and Adora gives a wave in return.

And that's the end of it.

Years of friendship just down the drain and exchanged for civil gestures and small talk.

But every time Adora sees her, she has the strangest urge to pull her in for a hug like she used to, or to just gravitate toward Catra and give her a touch on the shoulder or a gentle squeeze of her hand like they always did.

It's awful.

And yet, somehow, it's been four years.

Four years since Adora left for Eternia's prestigious veterinary program. Four years since she and Catra stopped talking. Four years—

Was it the distance? Was it something else?

Adora's still not even entirely sure.

And while Glimmer has had the best of intentions and has tried to convince her to move on and not expect closure, Adora still thinks about Catra sometimes.

And then, whenever Adora sees her again, she finds herself thinking about Catra *all the time.*

And now, as she sits in her car in the parking lot of her apartment complex, all Adora can think about is the strange, short, tense interaction she'd had with Catra earlier.

I'll come back later. When they're gone.

She wanders into the apartment she's sharing with Glimmer later that evening, with Adora recently graduated and recently moved back to Bright Moon.

Bow is in the kitchen hovering over pots and pans that sizzle and fill the room with some delicious smell, while Glimmer perches at the counter, waving to Adora when she walks in.

Bow turns around and greets Adora with a sad smile, one she recognizes from over the years anytime Catra is brought up.

"So I heard you saw Catra today," he greets.

"How did you—"

But then Adora's eyes widen as she remembers that Catra still talks to Bow. Which means Catra is thinking about this too.

"Thinking about Adora.

Hmm.

(She should know better than to have any false hope though.)

"She told you," Adora finishes.

Bow nods in confirmation.

"We still talk."

And even though Adora's here now, back in town after four years away, spending time with people who have close relationships with Catra still—

It doesn't mean anything is going to change.

Adora just sees Catra's wide eyes and locked shoulders and clenched fists before she started backing away from Adora. Like she'd seen a ghost.

"Well, considering she basically ran away from me, I don't think she's really interested in talking."

Bow sighs and switches one of the burners on the stove off before turning to face Adora, while Glimmer just groans.

"I still don't understand what happened between you two," Glimmer says. "Granted, I barely know her , but she and Bow are fine. What's different with you two?"

What's different is that I left, Adora thinks.

What's different is that there was a lot left unresolved.

A lot left unsaid.

A lot that Adora wanted answers to, but Catra left on a two-week vacation days after graduation as Adora was preparing to move. And then... they just didn't talk.

And Adora tried calling.

And Catra wouldn't answer .

Adora's been able to point to a few things over the past four years that may have led to Catra shutting her out, but she's never been able to fully nail it down for sure.

But, Adora supposes it doesn't even matter anymore.

"It's just complicated," is all Adora says in response.

Things always felt more complicated than they needed to be with Catra, a product of Adora's extreme ability to overthink things. From the moment she met Catra in one of the barns at Fright Zone Farms and going forward all the weekends they spent together perched atop a fence on their lunch breaks talking about anything and everything. To the time halfway through freshman year when Adora found Catra crying in the tack room over something Shadow Weaver had said to her, and Adora was there to hold her tightly until she could hear the rumble of a purr deep in Catra's chest. To the times they started working horses in the morning at the training track, and Catra ~~al~~always a better rider than Adora ~~w~~would sometimes push her horses a little more than she was supposed to just to pass Adora in

the end. And to all the time spent late at night in libraries studying, when Catra would bring Adora more coffee from the café down the street.

To the time they promised each other that someday it would be *you and me, together in the winners' circle.*

It was so easy for Adora to see what she wanted to see out of all the time spent with Catra over those four years, easy to pick out the parts that could give her the evidence she wanted. That maybe Catra wanted something more.

Because Adora always wanted more.

And Adora would go on dates with other girls, try and forget about how she was always thinking about her roommate and the way she'd laugh at Adora's jokes or the way she'd playfully call her an idiot and roll her eyes. But no relationship ever lasted long because at the end of the day, Adora would just want to go back to Catra and watch re-runs of their favorite shows or go hiking or go explore downtown Bright Moon with her.

But, Adora supposes it doesn't even matter anymore.

Adora left, and she knows it was still the right thing to do for herself, the right thing to do to accomplish what she'd been working so hard for.

But even the right choices are painful, she's found.

Adora stands at the kitchen counter of her and Catra's shared apartment, holding the letter in her shaking hands.

She got in.

The letter is telling her that she got into the best vet school in the country, and she wants to call the number included in the contact info at the top of the letter just to make sure they didn't get it wrong.

Because not only did she get in.

They're offering her a full-ride scholarship.

She's being offered a full-ride to the best vet school. She's really going to do this.

She's—

Just then, Adora hears keys jingling on the other side of the door until the person realizes its unlocked and turns the doorknob. The front door opens to reveal Catra, pulling her lanyard of keys out of the door with one hand and holding her phone in the other, staring down at it and not seeing Adora yet.

"Honey, I'm home," she calls jokingly.

Catra looks up and still doesn't see Adora, Catra's view of her obstructed by the way Adora's leaned against the refrigerator to hold herself up.

"Adora?" Catra calls out.

Adora still can't believe it.

Adora hears the sound of Catra's keys jangling still as she walks, getting closer and closer, rounding the corner and—

"Adora, what—"

Catra cuts herself off, eyes on the puddle of water on the kitchen floor and the broken glass that Adora dropped when she read the letter.

Catra finally peers up at Adora, face full of confusion, of concern, and Adora just stares back, still dumbfounded.

"I got my letter back. From Eternia's vet program," she says when she finally wills her voice to work again.

Catra reaches to snatch it out of Adora's grasp, stepping into Adora's space in a way that always makes her breath hitch because when Catra stands this close to her, she can feel her body heat and smell her and god*, Catra always smells so good.*

"Well, what does it say, dummy?"

Adora allows Catra to take the letter and looks down at the wet tile floor as Catra reads it.

"I got in," she mutters, just above a whisper, because she's still not entirely sure it's real.

Honestly, she wants Catra to read it over just to make sure she didn't somehow read it incorrectly.

"You—"

Catra scans her eyes over the letter, and her jaw drops after a few seconds.

It must be real.

"Adora, that's incredible."

*"Yeah," Adora replies, her throat sore from the way she yelled when she read the words "*Miss Grayskull, We are delighted to inform you that you've been accepted*"—*

"So," Catra begins, but trails off just as quickly.

"So…," Adora repeats, the tone of her voice curling up at the end like she's asking a question.

"Are you gonna go?"

Catra's staring at the letter when she asks, and there's less excitement in her voice than there was just a minute ago, Adora thinks.

“I really want to. I just—"

“Then you should go.”

She’s not sure what she was hoping Catra would say, but the words ring hollow in her ears. Her stomach drops. Sometimes when Adora’s not sure what she wants, caught between decisions, she’ll flip a coin or leave it up to chance somehow. Every time, in the in-between before chance makes the choice for her, she always has a tug toward one of the options. What she hopes it’ll be.

And that’s what this kind of feels like.

Adora finds she almost wishes Catra would ask her to stay.

Or ask if she’d come with her, or that she’ll make sure to visit, or something.

But all Catra says, with a neutral expression on her face, mouth barely lifting into a smile, is—

You should go.

And they don’t speak about it much after that.

(SUNDAY – SUNDAY – 3 BEFORE THE DERBY)

The next day, as she’s following Bo around for vet checks, Adora promises herself that she won’t make it a point to run into Catra somehow.

She swears.

But she and Catra have this knack for always finding their way back to each other it seems—all the times they’ve run into each other in the four years they’ve been apart and shrugged it off as nothing, and even before that. They’d end up in the same classes without even

trying, in the same group projects, in the same barns working together on the weekends.

Always in each other's orbits.

It's almost comforting to Adora to know that there's at least one thing about them that hasn't changed when she shows up to Barn 23 to do x-rays on one of her horses.

Catra's bent over in front of the horse, pressing gently on the horse's swollen front leg and barking orders to someone she recognizes from the day before named Scorpia. She watches Catra dust off her hands on her jeans and rise from her crouched position near the stable floor and groan, pinching her index finger and thumb between the bridge of her nose.

"Hey," Adora says simply.

She's not really sure what else to say.

I'm sorry?

Can we talk?

Are you okay?

Any words she thinks of feels like too much and not enough at the same time. But its fine, because quickly after Adora greets her, Catra is sighing heavily and asking, "What are you doing here, Adora?"

"X-rays. I'm here for x-rays."

Catra turns away then, clipping a lead rope to the bottom of the horse's halter while Lonnie unclips the barrier that holds the stall closed. Catra passes the rope off to Lonnie.

"Well, then talk to Lonnie about it. I've gotta go check on the results at Elberon."

Catra starts walking away from her once again, tension radiating off of her, even off the horse that Lonnie still holds, like the animal can pick up on it too.

Adora should really know not to get her hopes up.

But she turns to Ð . Hope anyway and says, "Will you just excuse me for a moment? Catra wanted me to check on another horse who' s favoring his left hind."

Ð . Hope believes the lie easily, nodding and letting Adora go chase after Catra, who's disappearing through a door in the middle of the barn.

Adora follows.

Catra closes her eyes and sighs when she sees the door open behind her, sees Adora standing in the threshold.

"Look, I know that we've been able to pretty much avoid each other for a long time"—

"Like four years?" Catra supplies, cocking an eyebrow and sitting down at her desk.

The air in the room is thick with all the words that have gone unspoken over those years.

"I hate that it' s been that long, Catra," Adora says, because she doesn't know what else to say .

Adora knows she shouldn't get her hopes up.

But fuck, she just wants to try .

"W ell, you left."

"Cat"—

Catra visibly bristles at the way the nickname easily falls off Adora’s lips.

“Don’t do that,” she says. Quietly. Like a threat.

Despite how close they’d become at the height of their friendship, Adora knows very well that Catra isn’t always the easiest person to get to know, remembers how much persistence it had taken to get her to believe that Adora wasn’t going to just decide to ditch her one day.

(And then, of course, Adora left.)

“What?”

“Don’t. Don’t do that. Don’t act like you know me.”

But even though this Catra in front of her may look a little older, and her hair is longer, her face more filled out and healthy-looking, lacking the dark circles around her eyes that often shadowed her cheeks from constant late nights in school, Adora knows that there’s still plenty of the Catra she knew in college sitting right in front of her.

“I do know you.”

“You knew me four years ago.”

Catra turns away from her again, firing up a laptop and typing.

“People change, Adora,” she adds.

And Adora’s sure that there’s plenty she doesn’t know about this version of Catra. But the awful thing is that Adora can’t help herself wanting to know what she doesn’t, that she wants to get to know Catra all over again.

And even still, there’s so much of the girl she knew that’s so painfully prevalent still.

"Yeah, well, thirty seconds with you and I can already tell you're just as stubborn and infuriating and"—

"Did you seriously show up here to insult me?"

Catra asks it in a biting tone, but the small smile that tugs on the corner of her lips cuts the sharpness just a little bit.

Adora shrugs and says, "I just want to get through this week."

And maybe someday, get back to where we were, she leaves unsaid.

Adora adds it to the rest of the words she won't say.

"And we're going to be working in close quarters," she continues. "I know this is probably really stressful for you and for me too, so"…

Catra's turned back to her laptop at this point, scrolling through a racing news website and pulling up a video.

"I just wanted to make sure we're on the same page."

The sound of a track announcer's voice plays too loudly against the silence of the room, the video Catra's pulled up starting to autoplay. She quickly presses pause and turns toward Adora once more.

"I've been civil to you for the past four years, haven't I?"

Civil. That's one way to put it, Adora thinks.

"You've avoided me as much as possible. You ignored all my calls," and if Adora says it with a little more malice than she originally intended, maybe it's not the worst thing in the world.

It still hurts, knowing that Catra was somehow able to just cut off her best friend like that. It still hurts, knowing that in the four years between then and now, there's been no apology or attempt on Catra's end to mend things.

t still hurts, and as much as she wants Catra back in her life, Adora knows she cant force it.

And it sucks being the only one trying.

Like a tug of war where only one person is pulling, the other end just falling easily over the center line in a hollow victory.

"You stopped trying after a few months."

And now Adora finds herself growing angry. Catra pushed her away, and she *tried.* Adora tried so hard. She left voicemails. She texted. But when Adora tried calling Catra on her birthday that fall, only to get no response—

There's only so much she could do before the message was received.

Catra clearly didnt want her around.

"What was Isupposed to do? Just grovel until you decided to answer?"

Catra turns back to the paused video, presses play.

Because the clang of starting gates opening and a booming voice calling *and they're off* is less awkward than the seemingly impossible amount of space between them.

"Yeah, whatever. Ican do civil. Ican do cordial," Catra mutters, just loud enough for Adora to hear over the sound of the race video.

Adora can barely see the look on Catra's face, can only see her in side profile as she stares hard at her screen, but Adora can tell from the hard line of Catra's mouth and the way she's clenching her jaw that she's struck a nerve.

And maybe even that Catra knows she's at least partially at fault for this.

"Just don't think this means we're friends or anything," Catra adds under her breath.

Not yet, Adora wants to say, but holds her tongue.

And that's one thing about Adora.

She doesn't go down without a fight.

Even in the most hopeless circumstances.

"I know you're friends with Bow. You should hang out with us sometime," Adora says, offering one more olive branch.

"Adora—"

Catra doesn't turn toward her, just keeps staring at the screen in front of her while Adora stares at the side of Catra's face. The side of her face, with her striking eyes that Adora can see welling up with tears.

Adora doesn't go down without a fight.

But she's also had to learn when to walk away.

"Right. Got it."

Adora sighs, turning away from Catra and heading back toward the door.

"I'll see you tomorrow," she says as her hand grips the door handle.

She turns it and opens the door. But she doesn't step out. Not yet.

Adora doesn't turn around, just looks down at the soft, dusty dirt barn floor beneath her and offers, "My number's still the same, by the way. If you have any issues with Melog, just reach out."

When Adora gets back to her apartment that night, Bow and Glimmer seem to know not to ask about Catra.

///

(MONDAY, FIVE DAYS BEFORE THE DERBY)

She still has Adora's number in her phone.

Catra hasn't deleted all of the pictures of them together either , and she'll claim that she only follows Adora on her social media accounts still to keep up with her in a professional manner. She sees her pictures from school, sees all the places she's traveled over the last four years, all the opportunities she's gotten.

Catra watches Adora's life in pictures sometimes, on those quiet barn mornings when Catra lets herself think of her, when she has the time and freedom to scroll through her phone aimlessly.

Today is one of those quiet mornings, her thumb hovering over the *message* button on Adora's contact information. It still reads *Adora Grayskull* with the little skull emoji and two small pink hearts floating next to it.

She should delete it.

She should have deleted it a long time ago, at least the emojis, and —

Catra doesn't get a chance to finish the thought because she can feel the presence of Shadow Weaver (another way Adora seems to stick with her, as she could never shake the nickname that she came up with for their boss) before she sees her.

Catra doesn't miss the way Melog pins his ears when Shadow Weaver reaches out a hand to pet his neck. She draws her arm back quickly with a disapproving "hmmph."

"How was Melog's work today?"

She asks it in a way that feels like she's trying to set Catra up—it always does. It always goes like this—Shadow Weaver trying to trip up Catra or somehow catch her in a lie, even when she knows that she's telling the truth.

"Good. He's training up to the race just as I want," Catra answers confidently.

Because it's true.

But Shadow Weaver crosses her arms over her chest and frowns.

"Then why did Entrapta tell me he was slower in his times today than he was yesterday?"

There it is.

Always trying to think she knows best for the horses when she barely sees them in action outside of race day. Always pushing Catra back into her shadow whenever she has the opportunity. Always thinking that Catra's way couldn't possibly be right.

It's been this way for years, since Catra started, and even after every time Catra has proven that she does know what she's doing, that she's more than competent—

Catra will never be enough for Shadow Weaver.

"You can't just base it on raw times alone. What I want out of him each day is different from the last. With all due respect, I'm not going to have him running balls to the wall every single morning."

Catra huffs out a sigh and puts her hands on her hips, nails digging into the bone there to keep herself from screaming.

Shadow Weaver just shakes her head and lets out a derisive laugh.

"All due respect—as if you've ever shown me the respect I deserve."

Maybe it's the Derby Week stress.

Maybe it's the fact that she's spoken more to Adora in the past day and a half than she has in a few years.

Maybe it's just a perfect storm of bottled-up emotions finally bubbling over.

"As if *you've* ever shown me the respect that *I* deserve."

Shadow Weaver's eyes narrow and her voice gets low when she asks, "What did you just say to me?"

And this is what keeps Catra from snapping back most of the time, what keeps her holding her tongue—this imposing, threatening figure before her who's done nothing but bark Catra into submission for years, done nothing but hurl insults her way hoping that one will stick in her side like a knife.

"You know that I only kept you around because Adora was fond of you. And then after that, it was because for some reason, Hordak believed in your potential. So while I still struggle to see your worth to this organization, you've somehow brought Melog this far."

It slices through Catra's heart, a heavy blow that has her gritting her teeth and clenching her jaw so tightly she fears something might break.

"Do not mess this up," Shadow Weaver adds before passing Catra with a bump to the shoulder, before disappearing behind her down the hall.

t’ s stupid, Catra tells herself.

You’re so stupid.

She’s so fucking stupid because even now, eight years later, she wants so badly to prove herself. She wants Shadow Weaver to know that she’s fucked up with how she’s treated Catra all these years. Ħat she is worth something. Ħat she’ s worth sticking around for. Ħat—

“Hey .”

Catra tenses even more at the sound of Adora’s voice somewhere behind her.

“Hey , Adora,” Catra greets, not even having the energy to let it come out in the standoffish way she’s been speaking with Adora the past two days.

Adora’s watching her with a look of concern and softness, and *damn it*, Catra hates that every interaction with Shadow Weaver leaves her feeling so raw that the way Adora’s looking at her isn’t entirely unwelcome.

t almost feels like they’re back in the barns at Fright Ƶone on a weekend together.

You look out for me, and I look out for you, Adora had told her after one particularly intense Shadow Weaver speech.

Nothing really bad can happen as long as we stay together.

But bad things happened when they stayed together.

And in some ways, even worse things happened when they didn’t.

“Look, I don’t mean to impose. I just"—

"Saw Shadow Weaver? Yes, she is still just as much of a bitch as she always has been. If you were wondering."

Catra turns away from Adora then, back to Melog, who has his head and neck hanging low out of his stall, waiting for Catra to scratch behind his ears. She reaches out to him and gently pets him, the motion calming her as she grazes her nails along his neck in a way that makes the horse tilt toward the sensation and relax his lower lip. She hears Adora stifle a laugh behind her, probably at the ridiculous, blissed-out look on Melog's face as Catra keeps petting him.

"Do you want to talk about it?"

She does. She *really* does. And it feels much too easy to let Adora back in after four years of trying to keep a steel trap around her heart. And she can't help but notice that being here with Melog, and being here with Adora, Catra almost feels safe.

Calm.

And that's not a common feeling for her.

So she opens the door just a crack.

"How someone can get so far in this business and not understand a training regimen is beyond me."

She's still turned away from Adora, like it's easier this way to talk to her for now while she's not facing her. Catra lets Melog burrow his nose against Catra's stomach as he huffs out a sigh while Catra massages behind the horse's ears.

"Well, that's why they pay you the big bucks to figure that out, right?"

Catra snorts and turns toward Adora only to roll her eyes.

"Oh come on, you've won the training titles at the Fraymor track meet how many consecutive times now?"

Oh.

(The answer is four .)

(But Catra wonders if Adora actually knows that and just isn't saying.)

She's also wondering how Adora knows any details of her career in the first place because that would mean—

"What, are you following my career?"

She turns toward Adora for real this time, stepping back from Melog and shifting so she's facing Adora, still keeping one hand twisted in Melog's mane to ground herself.

And Adora's cheeks are burning a faint red.

"I—

She shrugs and finally answers, "read. Obviously . I keep up with all of that."

Catra looks down at the ground and nods.

Of course. It's nothing special. *She's* nothing special. Adora keeps up with all of racing. It's part of her *job.* She only happens to notice Catra because she's been lucky enough to do well.

"But yeah, of course I wonder what you've been up to sometimes," Adora adds then, just above a whisper .

Oh.

"Oh."

Catra looks up in time to see Adora shifting her weight back and forth on her feet, swaying while she wrings her hands nervously.

An old Adora habit that hasn't died, Catra can see.

"But I, uh, was just passing through. But if you do want to talk about anything, just call."

"Thanks," Catra says, suddenly feeling a tightness in her throat that the word catches on.

It shouldn't tug at Catra's heart when Adora leans forward and gives Melog a gentle pat on the neck and says goodbye to him.

It shouldn't make her breath catch when she replays Adora saying she's kept up with her career, that she wonders what Catra's doing sometimes.

But Catra can't help but want to believe that Adora still cares about her after all this time.

Even after the way Catra colossally fucked up on graduation night. Even after Adora left.

And that's a memory she doesn't let herself think about, not when she's alone in her apartment and definitely not on those quiet mornings at the track.

This one stays locked, hidden.

Because all this memory does is serve to remind Catra that while Shadow Weaver might try and tear her down, might try and throw her off balance and mess with her—

No one can sabotage Catra better than the way she does it to herself.

Catra's trying to just enjoy the night and not think about the following facts:

1. *Adora is leaving to move to Eternia in two and a half weeks to start a summer internship before vet school.*

2. *Catra is going on a two-week vacation with some friends (a vacation that Adora was supposed to join in on as well until she discovered there was overlap with her internship) starting tomorrow and is barely going to see Adora before she leaves.*
3. *It's amazing what the prospect of losing someone to distance and not having told them you have a massive crush on them will do for yearning.*

So Catra's trying—she's really trying to just enjoy the party as all their friends and classmates mill about around them.

Adora's dancing like a fool around their little makeshift circle, Bow and his new girlfriend, Glimmer, laughing along with her while Adora's arms flail around a little aimlessly. Catra just rolls her eyes as the song changes, something mid-tempo and full of bass, as Bow and Glimmer break the circle to wrap up in each other.

Catra pulls Adora by the arm and yells over the music, "You're embarrassing me."

Adora just flashes her a dopey smile, swaying back and forth in somewhat of a rhythm with the music, a little drunk and flushed and looking stupidly gorgeous with her signature hair poof all mussed up.

"Then maybe you should teach me how to dance," Adora shouts back.

Adora has joked about this at several parties, well-aware of how uncoordinated she can appear on the dance floor, despite her athletic prowess in nearly every other area. (Catra's no stranger to Adora's biceps and abs.)

But every time, Catra just rolls her eyes harder and shoves Adora by the shoulder and says something like "I'm going to go get another drink."

But now, Adora comes closer, wrapping her arms around Catra's neck in something that's a half-hug and half…something else.

And it makes Catra's brain stop working.

"You know, here we are, graduation night, and you still haven't taught me how to dance in a way that doesn't embarrass you," Adora whispers in her ear.

Catra inhales sharply and puts her hands on Adora's (rock-hard) forearms, untangling them from their spot around Catra's neck.

This is dangerous territory.

This is always *dangerous territory.*

Catra's tipsy, and surely Adora is too, and…

She's not sure how much more of this she's going to get.

"And I'm not sure you can be helped, Adora," Catra replies light-heartedly, as Adora pouts and reaches for Catra once again.

"Oh, come on."

Catra catches her by the wrists and squeezes, saying, "You're giving everyone a great show just the way you are right now."

"Liar."

It's not out of the ordinary for them to be this physical with each other —hell, Adora has fully hip-checked Catra into stacks of hay bales before, one time nearly causing them to fall over (and send Adora tumbling down on top of her when Catra reached out to steady herself with Adora's arm).

But this?

This feels different.

"Come on, Cat," Adora says teasingly as she starts to sing along to the song.

It feels different.

(It's probably just the knowing that they won't have this anymore.)

(But that in itself is almost too powerful and sending Catra toward doing something she'll probably regret.)

"Teach me some of those sweet moves."

Catra pokes Adora's forehead and can't help but laugh at the way it seems to be a push-button for her to still completely, no longer swaying back and forth on the dance floor in a half-rhythm.

"You are such an idiot."

Adora grins, and fuck*, Catra is powerless to resist.*

Catra keeps dancing in front of Adora, moving her hips in time to the music and nervously running a hand through her hair.

No time like the present.

"Follow my lead," Catra says.

She takes a deep breath and reaches for Adora's wrists once again and positions her hands on Catra's hips.

It's not even the most precarious position they've been in before. But it just feels different.

Tense.

It feels tense.

"Is this all I have to do?" Adora shouts over the music.

"It's a start. But I can't have you looking like an idiot in front of all those girls at Eternia."

Adora cocks an eyebrow, and Catra wonders if she's imagining the way Adora tightens her grip on her hips. Adora's hands suddenly feel like the only thing keeping her on the ground, keeping her present.

Catra wonders if she imagines the way Adora takes a step closer, and suddenly the few inches of height between them feels overwhelming as Adora seems to tower over her—strong, powerful, and still so gentle.

And no idea that along with her hips, she's holding Catra's heart in her hands.

And Catra realizes she can't even pinpoint the moment she fell for Adora.

She knows that something sparked in her the moment they met. She knows that something took hold the first time Adora told her that nothing bad could happen as long as they stayed together. *But even in all the big moments that come to mind, the memorable things that Adora's said to her, Catra wonders if it happened somewhere in the quiet.*

In subtle smiles over cleaning stalls on the weekends. In classrooms when Catra would mutter something sarcastic under her breath, and the one time Adora couldn't hold back her laughter and spit iced latte all over her laptop keyboard. In the all the little things.

"Who said I'm interested in what they think?" Adora asks, and its quiet compared to all the other things she's said, but to Catra, it sounds the loudest.

Catra knows she has a habit of finding meaning in things where there is none, and she can't afford to let herself overthink this one.

She doesnt mean it like that *, Catra tells herself over the thrum of the bass as the song changes again, this time to something even slower.*

"You're drunk, dummy."

But Adora just gives her a lop-sided smile, and Catra nearly drops to the floor when Adora's gaze seems to flicker down, and—

"No, I'm not."

Dnt read into it dont read into it dont read into it

"Dance with me?" Adora asks, and Catra is certain that the only thing keeping her upright is the way Adora is holding her hips still.

But she's powerless to resist Adora.

She always has been.

She wonders if she probably always will be.

And there's no alcohol on earth that could get Catra as drunk as the way it feels to have Adora's eyes completely glued to her like they are right now, staring at her like she's a marvel. Like she's all Adora can see.

Like she doesn't have anything to prove to anyone.

"You're such an idiot," Catra mumbles, but this time, she's the one wrapping arms around shoulders, and instead of pushing Adora away, she pulls her closer.

Just this once.

"I know."

Adora's hands slide from Catra's hips around to the small of her back and pull her closer. Catra follows the momentum, and she ends up with her front pressed against Adora's and barely breathing in shallow bursts because she's afraid that if she moves too much, if she's not still enough, that somehow she's going to shatter the moment.

Her chin rests on Adora's shoulder, and Catra feels her let out a shaky exhale.

"How am I doing?" she hears Adora whisper, dangerously close to her ear, and Catra can feel the rumble of Adora's voice vibrate against her.

It's overwhelming.

Bow and Glimmer's laughter peeling through the packed bar completely fades out, along with the sounds of whatever Top 40 slow song they're dancing to. Catra's not even sure what it is but wonders if she hears it years from now if she's going to remember this, if she's going to have this entire moment committed to memory.

Catra's trying to just enjoy the night, enjoy Adora while she still has her.

But she's become all too aware of the following facts:

1. *Adora is leaving to move to Eternia in two and a half weeks to start a summer internship before vet school.*
2. *Catra is going on a two-week vacation starting tomorrow and is barely going to see Adora before she leaves.*
3. *This might be her last chance to do anything about the terrible, bottomless pit of feelings she's fallen in over the years.*
4. *As calculated and strategic as she is, there's something about Adora that makes Catra a little bit bolder. A little more reckless.*

Maybe a little impulsive.

Catra lifts her chin off Adora's shoulder and tilts her head back to come face-to-face with a softly smiling Adora.

Dnt read into it, *shouts her head.*

Kss her , *shouts something else deep in Catra's heart.*

And Catra doesn't think about it anymore, is tired of overthinking it all. She wonders what it would be like if she just stopped thinking for a second and focused on what's in front of her—Adora with her big blue eyes, staring back at her with her mouth dropped open just a little bit like she might want to say something and—

And she leans in to press her lips against Adora's.

Unsurprisingly, Adora's lips are soft and warm, and Catra just holds there for a half-second, lips pressed against Adora's mouth, waiting for her to kiss back.

Catra hears a sharp inhale as she leans in, and then a squeak—of surprise? Of what Catra's not really sure.

But surely Adora's brain has had enough time to process this by now.

And she's not kissing Catra back.

Dnt read into it yet, *says her heart this time.*

Absolutely read into it, *says her head.*

And Catra pulls back quickly, unwrapping her arms from Adora's neck like she's a flame, like she's the sun.

Of course, Catra couldn't help herself and got too close.

Adora's eyes are wide and her mouth is open even wider, hands hanging uselessly at her sides as Catra's voice struggles to make any kind of sound, let alone any coherent words.

She thinks she mumbles an "I'm so sorry" before turning on her heel and disappearing into the crowd.

She thinks she might hear Adora call her name over the crowd.

So she runs.

And she hopes she never hears this stupid song again.



(TUESDAY—FOUR DAYS BEFORE THE DERBY)

Another thing that Catra appreciates about horses is that when she comes to stand at the rail, watching them run circles around the track, she can focus on what's in front of her. She can focus on what

the animals are doing and how they're moving and *why is Kyle pulling so tightly on the reins* and not think about anything else.

Not think about Adora.

She's *not* going to think about Adora. She doesnt call her even though Adora left that door open yesterday, after Catra saw Shadow Weaver. And if she stared at Adora's contact page for a few minutes, thumb hovering over the *Message* and *Call* buttons, then Adora will never know.

"Hey ," Catra suddenly hears from behind her , slightly annoyed that someone's disturbed her peace.

She always stands away from the other trainers in the mornings on purpose, but especially this week.

Away from the cameras.

Away from the interviews.

She craves the quiet in the midst of the chaos.

But Catra looks back over her shoulder to see Bow smiling at her, hands in his jacket pockets and sidling up next to her at the rail.

"Hey , Bow."

She and Bow are definitely on better terms than her and Adora, and Catra still considers him a close friend, but most often, their time catching up is in moments like these. Away from the crowds in the morning at the track.

But Catra kind of likes that it's become their thing.

"So, Adora' s back in the picture."

"She' s not in the picture. She just happens to be interning with the track vet at the most important race meet of the year."

Catra keeps facing forward, toward the dirt oval, trying to track Melog's movement as he disappears behind the giant odds board in the middle of the infield. But she sneaks a glance to her right to see Bow with a smirk on his face.

Ugh.

It's annoying how good of a friend Bow is.

How perceptive he is. How intuitive he is.

How he can tell exactly what's bothering Catra without even asking.

"She mentioned that you two talked."

"We're on civil terms," Catra replies in a clipped tone.

"And is that enough?"

Catra's been stepped on by massive horse hooves multiple times in her career—the yelp of pain and surprise that comes with the loveable (but sometimes blissfully unaware) animals taking a sidestep right onto a toe.

Bow's question kind of feels like that.

But Catra just grips at the rail with her hands and watches as Melog rounds the final turn into the homestretch.

"You two were best friends, Catra."

She listens only to the sound of the horse's footfalls against the dirt, trying to ignore the way the sound seems to time perfectly with her heartbeat—faster and faster as the words reverberate.

You two were best friends.

They were. And then Catra ruined it all because she let herself want more.

"I can't imagine barely talking to Glimmer for four years, and then what I would do if she just showed up in my life again."

Melog runs faster still, legs outstretched and reaching, grabbing for the surface beneath him, while Catra wishes she could reach for something else to hold on to. The rail suddenly doesn't feel like enough to hold her up. The horse is close enough now that she can hear the noisy breathing through his flared nostrils as he tears toward the finish line, a fire in his eyes while Kyle holds him back to preserve his energy. Catra knows the feeling. She's ready to bust out of here too.

"You and Glimmer are literally engaged," Catra finally grits out.

She watches Melog cross the finish line and start to slow as they round the first turn again, gaze following the bay horse as he runs away from where Catra's standing, his form getting smaller as he rounds the first turn again.

"It's not—it wasn't like that with me and Adora."

I wanted it to be.

But it wasn't.

"Okay, fine then," Bow says with a shrug. "I can't imagine barely talking to Sea Hawk for four years."

"Your life would be so much more peaceful. So much less fire."

They both laugh at that, and Catra watches as Kyle slows Melog to a jog on the other side of the track and starts heading back toward the barns on the outer rail, Lonnie and Scorpia there to greet them. Catra falls quiet after that, Bow waving and shouting a few commands to the exercise rider on his farm's horse, Swift Wind.

And she stops thinking about Adora.

She's four days out from the Derby—she needs to *focus.*

Melog.

Yes. Melog.

Melog looked strong today. Shadow Weaver will probably give her shit later for his times, and maybe Entrapta's calculations hold some weight—

But the horse looks good. He looks strong. And that's what Catra's after right now. Not bullet workouts that leave him sore or tandem gallops with another horse that might burn him out before Saturday, or—

"Do you miss her?"

Catra inhales sharply.

Because she's very actively trying to *not* think about Adora. Because *of course* she still misses her.

It's not as intense as it felt when Adora first left, when Catra came back after her vacation to see Adora's things all packed up in their shared apartment and that last awkward goodbye when Adora left a few days later. It's not an all-consuming ache that left Catra feeling so angry at herself and so numb to the rest of the world. Not anymore.

But she still thinks about Adora all the time.

"She left me like I was nothing," Catra says quietly, and she knows that that's barely even the half of it.

"Catra—"

"I get it. Getting into Eternia's veterinary program is like, incredibly difficult, and she absolutely deserved it, but—"

"Are you mad that she left or mad that she didn't ask you to go with her?" Bow asks.

Both.

And truthfully, Catra's still the most angry at herself. Because as much as Shadow Weaver, Hordak, anyone really, can try and drag her down—

No one can sabotage Catra better than the way she does it to herself.

"And why would she ask me that?" Catra shoots back, and any malice behind it is less directed at Bow and more at herself.

"Because you two were like, attached at the hip. It would have been a fair question."

And maybe it would have been. Maybe it wouldn't have been weird for Catra to have admitted to Adora that she'd been looking into jobs at tracks on the east coast to come join her. Maybe it wouldn't have been out of the ordinary for Adora to ask if Catra wanted to come with.

But Catra never told her that.

And Adora never asked.

And—

"It doesn't even matter now anyway."

With Melog headed back to the barn, Catra picks out Swift Wind as a focal point, eyeing the white horse jogging slowly up the backstretch, warming up for a longer workout. Catra feels Bow bump his hip against hers.

"Then why are we standing here, and why are you looking out at the track like you're waiting for a lost lover to return from the war?"

"Oh, shut up. I am not."

"Are too."

(And Catra's not blushing. She's not.)

"I dont know ," Catra mutters, just above a whisper and staring at the concrete below. "What do you think?"

Bow sighs, thoughtfully, and where Catra keeps staring down, she can see just out of the corner of her eye as Bow looks up, taking in the blue sky above them.

"I think"…

He trails off with a "hmm," and then Bow , who seems to have such a deep understanding of those around him, an insight that only comes from careful observation of both Catra and Adora over the years, speaks again.

"I think this world has tried so hard to make you cold."

Catra keeps looking down, gripping at the rail with her hands and feeling her claws digging into it. Maybe it's the kind, gentle way Bow says it, Catra knowing how genuine the sentiment is, or maybe it's the way the wind is whipping up dirt from the track in front of them, but she feels her eyes sting with tears.

"She makes you softer ," he continues. "Hold onto that, okay?"



Where Bow’s earlier question felt like a half-ton of horse weight pressing down on her foot, this feels more like when Melog presses his forehead into Catra’s chest and lets her hold his head and scratch under his chin. And the softness of it grabs at Catra’s throat, makes her swallow down a lump that she didnt expect.

"We've hung out together, like, once since all this happened," Catra replies, trying to hide the way her voice wavers.

"Yeah, and you already seem like this weight's been lifted off your shoulders."

She inhales sharply. Catra's annoyed that Bow can see it better than she can. She won't let herself admit that yes, she *does* feel a little lighter after yesterday's encounter with Adora, that Adora *does* in fact still know Catra better than she'd like to admit.

Because along with that comes admitting that she still cares about Adora so much.

That she still dreams about all the ways that kiss could have gone differently.

"Bow, don't be ridiculous."

"You mattered so much to each other, Catra. You both still do, I think."

Of course she still matters to me.

"I mean, damn, if nothing else, do it for me and Glimmer. We're sick of the tension."

Catra rolls her eyes.

She can't.

She won't.

"Shut up."

But when Catra heads back to the barn and passes by Adora, who gives her a big smile and wave as she looks over another horse's x-ray, it sticks with Catra long after she walks by. And when Catra finally reaches Melog, all she can think about is the way Adora gently

pet him and said "Bye, Melog!" when she left yesterday , the way the horse leaned into Adora's touch like he didn't want her to go.

Something Catra's always appreciated about horses is the way they see right through people.

It's not something she appreciates right now.

Chapter End Notes

they're so stupid and repressed in every fic i write and i love that for them! side note, this fic has a playlist.

in the words of scorpia, i've had a REAL challenge of a day today and haven't posted any fic in a month so im not even gonna pretend im not dying for comments.

next chapter comes on friday , may 14th for big bang week and will be featuring some amazing art from both artists!

far turn

Chapter Summary

an awkward conversation over coffee. a confession by a fountain. a bit of frustration in a barn.

Chapter Notes

hello and happy big bang week to you all!there are some wonderful fics out there that have been posted in the big bang collection, which you can access here. lots of artists and writers have worked very hard to put out some high quality content, so please give them the love they deserve.

welcome to down to the wire part two. this has been a collaborative effort with two incredible artists. follow them both on twitter @blackcleryberry_ and @sunflowerpau__ i have gone back and added some of their art to part one, so please go check that out, and you'll see more of their art throughout today's chapter!

additionally, because i like to make more work for myself apparently, i wrote a song to go with this fic!it's called "long shot"and its based on catra's point of view . you can listen to that here, and while you're there, feel free to listen to my other stuff!

thank you all for the feedback on part one. and without further ado, here is the next chapter of catra and adora's horse girl summer.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

(TUESDAY AFTERNOON – FOUR DAYS BEFORE THE DERBY)

Apparently four years of running from Adora has caught up with Catra, as she seems to run into her at every possible turn now. It's only fair, she supposes, when Catra is talking to Lonnie about scheduling another horse's next race and hears the sound of Adora's voice calling out her name.

"Catra?"

Catra whirls around and sees Adora standing at the barn entrance, looking timid and holding a small case of vet supplies in her hands, her stupid lab coat once again tied around her waist and not covering the blue short sleeve First Ones Veterinary Hospital shirt that unfortunately shows off the cut of Adora's arms, which have only gotten more defined since college.

It's really not fair.

"Hey , Adora," is all Catra says in reply , letting it roll off her tongue casually like it used to every morning while she desperately tries not to notice the way the shirt also brings out the blue in Adora's ocean eyes.

"Hi," Adora replies simply , continuing to stand awkwardly just inside the barn entrance and not making any effort to move closer.

She looks nervous.

Catra turns back to Lonnie and mutters a quick, "Will you excuse us?" before turning back toward Adora as Lonnie busies herself down the hall with another one of the horses.

"Can I help you?"

Catra can't help but feel like she has the upper hand as she quirks an eyebrow up and watches as Adora anxiously shifts her weight back and forth on her feet before she finally starts walking closer to Catra, holding up the box of supplies in her hands.

And Catra's so glad that Melog is on the other side of the barn so that she can better hide the way her stomach is turning and her heart is beating fast and *why the fuck does Adora still have to be so hot* as she walks closer.

"I uh—I'm here for Melog's drug test."

Catra snorts. This is quickly becoming the longest interaction they've had in four years, and of course, it has to be about *this.*

"Came to get a piss sample from my horse and not for my amazing company?"

Catra can't help it, and it seems to break the tension, a small, tentative smile forming on Adora's face.

"We weren't really sure that was an option based on the last time we spoke," she hears Adora say, just above a whisper. Like maybe Catra wasn't even supposed to hear it.

And the tension surges back over them again like Catra and Adora are just tiny pebbles on a beach, waiting to get tugged back out into the ocean by the waves. Waiting to sink down into oblivion and into the uncertainty that's surrounded them for four years.

The silence washes over them, and Adora nearly drops the handle of the case she holds while fiddling with it with her hands.

They've never been good at this part—having to dive head first into the discomfort.

If they were, they probably would have solved a lot of this a long time ago, Catra thinks.

But then Catra finds out one way that Adora has changed in the four years they've been apart when she takes a deep breath and a step closer, looks up at Catra with an unreadable expression on her face and starts, "Look, Cat—Catra. I know it's been awhile."

Adora's always been brave—reckless, even. But that was usually when it came to training yearlings that no one else wanted to be around, dodging kicks from expectant mothers in the foaling barn, tearing around the track on a horse who needed a bullet workout. Not as much when it came to emotions.

She continues, "I never wanted to leave you, you know. I just—"

Catra sucks in a breath and feels like she's been sucker punched. They're really doing this. Here, in a fucking horse barn four days before the Etherian Derby, and Catra has so much to do, and—

"You got an offer you couldn't refuse, Adora. How could I hold that against you?"

Catra says it and hopes that'll be the end of it.

(Part of her hopes Adora will keep pushing. Part of her always hopes that Adora will keep coming back, and she hates herself for it.)

"Then why are you, still?" she hears Adora ask as Catra stares down at the ground, rubbing a rut into the dirt with the toe of her boot.

A loaded question.

"It's been so long. We're different people now."

What she wants to say is:

Because you left.

Because I was in love with you, and I didn't know how to deal with it.

Because I was stupid and pushed you away, and I think I'm a little embarrassed by the whole thing.

Adora sighs and answers, "I think you'll find that we're really not as different as you seem to think. I'm still Adora. Ask Bow and Glimmer."

Catra still doesnt look up.

"Look, Im free after this, and if you wanted to get cof fee or something"—

Catra finally snaps her head up at that. But whatever else Adora was going to say is cut off as Scorpia comes jogging up behind her .

"Hey , boss! Got your sample right here. Oh, hello! Ð . Grayskull, right?"

Adora's eyes widen at Scorpia, like she's completely forgotten that the whole reason she was supposed to be here in the first place was to get a drug test sample for Melog and not to start the long road of attempting to be friends with Catra again.

"Y es. Hi, Scorpia. Ill just take that."

Scorpia lingers for a few moments, like she's waiting to join in on the conversation, until Catra turns toward her and jerks her head in the direction Scorpia came, hoping shell get the meaning that Catra' s trying to say *I'm a little busy right now.*

Catra watches as Scorpia looks to her and then over to Adora before breathing out a quiet *oh* and adding, "Right! Thatll be all. Ill see you later, Catra! Bye, Ð . Grayskull!"

Scorpia leaves again, and Catra watches as Adora gives her a small wave while her cheeks burn a faint red.

And then remembers that Adora's left her with an open invitation to continue this conversation.

t' s tempting to say no, to just get through the next few days and hope that she and Adora can magically stay away from each other, even though every piece of evidence suggests that thatll be completely impossible.

t' s tempting to make the safe choice that she's always made with Adora—shove it all way down and dont get hurt. Or dont get hurt any worse than she already has. But the thing about Catra, the thing that made her surge forward and kiss Adora in the first place, is that Adora makes her braver.

Maybe a little reckless.

(Or maybe she just finally wants to break free from the self-sabotage for once in her goddamn life.)

"So where are we going?" Catra finally asks.

Adora, who has zoned out staring at her phone in the time since Scorpia left and the silence washed over them again, jerks her head up suddenly.

"Huh?"

"Cof fee. Ican do cof fee. Where are we going?"

The grin that lights up Adora' s eyes, and really, her whole face, shouldnt make Catra' s heart skip a beat. But it's the same smile that Adora used to give her years ago whenever Catra would say something particularly funny or choose to not double down on her insistence that her saying something remotely kind to Adora *is not because I like you.*

And that's what Catra keeps telling herself the entire way to the coffee shop. Because it might be the only way she gets through this conversation with some of her dignity still intact.

This is not because I like her.

Maybe this is just closure, Catra tells herself.

They end up at a small café a few minutes from the track, short enough for the walk to be silent without it being too awkward, too tense.

Catra orders a decaf latte because it's much too late in the day for her to have caffeine and risk the aftermath of this conversation keeping her up even later than she already knows that it will. They remain quiet while they order, Adora not commenting on how Catra still orders the same drink she would go to regularly in college, and Catra not commenting on how the college version of Adora would never drink something as bitter as an americano.

Adora's the first to speak when they finally sit down at a booth in the corner.

"So seems like things have been pretty busy for you since you started training for Fright Zone."

Catra shrugs and settles into the small talk, saying, "Just kind of happened naturally. You remember how junior year after I started doing more of the exercise rider stuff, Hordak noticed how good I was with the horses, how observant I was with things. Just kind of progressed from there."

Catra keeps her hands wrapped around the warm mug that holds her drink, the burn of the ceramic against her palms a welcome distraction from the way Adora smiles softly at her when she answers.

"I'm really proud of you," Adora replies.

And she says it so genuinely, so *gently*. Catra knows Adora means the statement with every bit of pride within her, and it makes Catra want to throw up and throw her drink across the room and throw herself at Adora all at the same time.

She's missed this~~for~~ as much as they would poke and prod each other at work, trading light shoves and punches to the shoulder as much as they'd banter back and forth (much to the delight of Bow), Catra could never resist how damn *sweet* Adora could be.

"Not that~~not~~ that you need my approval to"—

"Adora."

Adora goes quiet again, only the sound of her drumming her fingers against the table top and the whirring sounds of a coffee grinder filling the empty shop.

"Thank you," Catra says, looking right at Adora and regretting it immediately. Because Adora's eyes are a fucking *trap*. They always have been. And it's completely unfair that Catra can take one look at that stupid face of hers and get completely lost all over again.

This is not because you like her.

This is not *because you like her.*

She's repeating it to herself over and over again. This is closure at minimum and the start of being acquaintances again at most.

But Adora must notice the way Catra's jaw loosens, the way her shoulders drop the tension in them, the way she feels her whole face soften just looking at Adora.

Because then Adora goes beyond small talk.

"Why did you stop talking to me?"

Adora asks the question in such a small voice, and Catra thinks the only other time she's heard that tone from Adora is the night she found out she got into Eternia, the way she'd said *I got in*~~like~~ she still wasn't sure it was real, like she wasn't sure she wanted to make it heard by saying it out loud.

And Catra's not sure she wants to make any of this heard by saying it out loud either. They could stop right here~~C~~atra could shut it down, and they could keep doing this awful dance around each other every time they inevitably run into each other.

"Just jumping right into things, huh?" Catra asks, not bothering to try and suppress the edge of anger that cuts through her tone.

“W ell, we never even talked about it, Catra.”

Catra barely allows herself to *think* about it. Sometimes she physically cringes when she thinks of graduation night. Sometimes shell actually shake her head like she can get rid of the thought if she makes herself dizzy enough. Sometimes she dreams about it and cant *help* but think of kissing Adora.

“Which part?” Catra asks quietly .

“All of it,” Adora answers, taking a sip of her cof fee and grunting at how hot the drink still is.

But the next question Adora asks burns hotter .

“Why tell me to leave if you didnt actually want me to?”

t’ s an unfortunate thing that being in such close proximity to someone, in knowing them as well as Adora and Catra knew each other, that they could (and apparently still can) read each other so well. And Adora seems to fill in the gaps all too easily.

“What was Isupposed to tell you?” Catra grits out. “That you should stay at Fright Zone with me when you had the chance to go to the best vet program in the country? One of the best in the world? Just because Id miss you?”

t’ s like Adora’s flipped a switch on her, and now that she’s started talking, Catra’s not sure she can stop. Like Adora’s opened the floodgates.

Like one small question that doesnt even fully get to the heart of the matter can be the thing that finally sets Catra off. The straw that breaks the camel’s back.

She couldnt just tell Adora that she wanted her to stay . She couldnt put that kind of pressure on her.

"I missed you, too, you know ," Catra hears Adora say , breaking through the whirlwind in Catra's thoughts.

Logically, she knows that Adora had to miss her at least a little bit—they'd spent four years together and were nearly inseparable. Of course, Adora missed her.

"I still do."

Oh.

Catra's not sure she was expecting that.

"Adora, this is a lot after four years"—

"I know . I know ."

But Catra knows it's going to feel overwhelming no matter when they do this. It's going to feel overwhelming still if they *never* talk about it. There's either going to be an Adora-shaped hole in her heart for the rest of her life, or she can start putting the pieces back in, even if they are a little out of alignment to start.

And besides—

It's not because I like her.

"I convinced myself that it was easy for you to leave me behind. And that's the story I kept telling myself," Catra says, shrugging.

Catra has to avert her eyes from the pained look on Adora's face.

"Cat"—

"Adora, don't."

Catra could shut it down, and they could keep doing this awful dance around each other every time they inevitably run into each other.

And then she thinks of Melog with Adora, and how Adora's stupid presence still makes her feel safe after all these years, and how Adora genuinely wants to listen and be here with her right now. t' s enough to drive her mad~~how~~ Adora is still so persistent after all this time.

t' s exactly what Catra' s always wanted from her.

And it's still so fucking frustrating.

Because in return, Catra has to be vulnerable. Catra has to open up.

And she's terrified.

"And aftergraduation"…

She's still not looking up at Adora.

"figured Ihad ruined everything anyway ."

Catra retreats into herself, slinking her hands away from the table and into her lap, wringing her hands together and resisting the urge to dig her claws into the flesh of her thighs. t sounds so stupid when she says it out loud, to just assume that she had broken something and made it irreparable by one action.

"Catra"…

"never said it was healthy . Or smart," Catra bites back.

She *knows* her well-developed ability to self-sabotage is unhealthy. She's been in therapy for long enough to know this and try ways of breaking the pattern. But thatdoesn't always make it easy .

Especially not when it comes to Adora.

"Shadow W eaver convinced me you were better off without me anyway. That Iwas just a thorn in your side, something holding you back."

Catra remembers all the awful things Shadow Weaver would tell her even before Adora announced that she was leaving—how after Adora showed up and became the best employee of the weekend barn staff, *Catra only served to hold her back. Catra wasn't as good as Hordak seemed to think she was. Of course Catra wouldn't go onto bigger and better things like Adora was—*

"That was never true, Catra."

"And I know that. I know that now. I just—"

The words get caught in her throat, but only for a moment. Like the flow of a river right before it topples over a waterfall. There's only a second that she gets to pause, look around, and see where she's at.

But Catra can't stop herself from falling right over the edge.

"I was young and dumb, and I just wanted you to stay."

And there it is, out in the open, four years too late. Catra telling her she wanted her to stay. And Adora just stares back, mouth partially open, brow furrowed, like hearing Catra actually say it out loud has just broken something in her brain.

"We could have talked about it."

Catra's glad that she still has her hands in her lap because Adora reaches across the table seemingly out of instinct, only to realize there's no hand for her to grab onto.

"Catra, I—"

Catra retreats into herself further.

"Maybe this wasn't such a good idea," she mumbles.

She can feel herself starting to panic—the paced breathing exercises she's learned over the years are helping to slow the rising tide of

anxiety, but its not quite enough. She just feels the waves lap higher and higher until it feels like it's starting to suffocate her.

Maybe she's ready to get this far, but she's not ready to talk about… that.

She's not ready to talk about the kiss.

Just thinking about it in front of Adora makes her feel so *foolish.* So *stupid.*

"Catra, come on," Adora pleads, hand still reaching across the booth as Catra starts to scoot herself out of her seat.

She needs to get out of here.

She needs to go back to the barn.

Maybe Melog can calm her down.

"Catra"—

Catra doesn't look back at Adora, trying to slow her breathing and blink back the tears that form behind her eyes. She is *not* about to have a panic attack in the middle of a coffee shop. She pushes the door open but doesn't hear it close behind her and knows that Adora must be following her.

"Catra, you kissed me, and then we never even talked about it!" she hears Adora call.

She hears the way Adora's voice breaks over the syllables of her name. The way her voice gets breathless over the word *kissed.* The way Adora sounds so hurt by the end that she can barely get out of the last few words.

It's too much. It's just too much.

So she does what she always has done to keep herself safe—Catra pushes.

"There's nothing to talk about, Adora!" she yells, turning around to see Adora's face fall, see those annoying beautiful eyes full of defeat.

It's too much. It's just too much.

"It was four years ago. It was—it was a stupid crush," Catra adds, trying to convince herself just as much as she's trying to convince Adora.

Adora just stares blankly, nods faintly, and doesn't say a word.

"I'm gonna go," Catra adds, and turns around before she can talk herself out of it.

And not for the first time in Catra's life, she leaves Adora standing alone, confused, with no resolution.

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(WEDNESDAY, THREE DAYS BEFORE THE DERBY)

Adora's tried for years to get that kiss out of her head.

It comes and goes in waves—a rigorous veterinary program proved at times to be enough to get Catra off her mind, especially after the first few months when Adora realized that Catra wasn't going to answer any of her calls. But every now and then, the feeling of Catra's lips pressing against Adora's haunts her.

It mostly shocked her, when it happened. And Adora knows that maybe it would have been good to give Catra any kind of indication

in the moment that she wanted her too. But by the time Adora got over the initial shock that *this isn't one of your dreams*, Catra was pulling away and apologizing. And by the time Adora got up the courage to try and reach out to Catra, it seemed like it was too late.

Catra wouldn't call back. Wouldn't text back. Nothing.

Four years, just down the drain. And besides—apparently it was just a stupid crush anyway.

Adora also knows that *whatever* that kiss was is not the only thing that they need to clear up.

There's the whole bit about how Catra wanted Adora to stay. There's the whole bit about how maybe Adora loved Catra enough that she would have considered staying if she would have asked. There's the whole part where Adora's pretty sure that she still has feelings for Catra, as ridiculous as it sounds even in Adora's own head.

(That part, Adora tells herself, she can just box up and put on the shelf. She can be content with being Catra's friend.)

She can totally be Catra's friend. If Catra wants to be, that is. Adora's not really sure where yesterday's botched coffee shop meeting leaves them.

Which is why she's pacing back and forth around her and Glimmer's apartment in a red dress, waiting for Glimmer to finish getting ready before they all head off to a Derby Week gala thrown by Angella and Micah, Glimmer's parents and owners of Bright Moon Stable.

A huge Derby week gala full of all the connections to all twenty horses running in the race. Including Catra.

"It's just dinner," Bow says, watching as Adora burns a track in the carpet, circling the coffee table in the living room like she's the one running a race in a few days, and not Melog and Swift Wind.

t" s dinner with *Catra.*"

Glimmer emerges from the bedroom and adds, "And me and Bow . Youll be fine. Besides, Ialso need a buf fer if Im going to be around Catra that long."

Bow rolls his eyes and replies, "Y ou barely know her."

"W ell, she hasnt exactly been the friendliest in our previous interactions."

From what Adora's gathered about most of Glimmer and Catra's interactions, Catra loves to be a thorn in Glimmer's side. Theyre too similar. Adora and Bow can easily see it even if the two of them cant. And it probably makes it all too easy for Catra to push Glimmer's buttons. And vice-versa.

Bow clears his throat and says, "Besides, itll be at a very public place, so there will be no room for fighting. Right?"

His eyes dart back and forth between Glimmer and Adora, who are both staring at him with grimaces.

"Right?" he asks again, his voice more pleading this time.

Adora and Glimmer let out a sigh and a resigned "yeah" in unison.

She's been to events where Catra's been in attendance in the last four years. The dif ference is, Adora was able to keep her distance then. She's really not sure what tonight will bring. In the past, Adora's been able to push down any anger and hurt she still feels toward Catra with a steady regimen of throwing herself into her work and hitting the gym. But that was before Catra was right in front of her, in close quarters, on a daily basis.

But it's fine. Itll be so fine.

"Now come on," Bow adds with a bright smile. "T ime to enjoy the fact that having a Derby horse gets us lots of free drinks and hors

d'oeuvres."

The party, hosted at Micah and Angella's opulent Bright Moon Stable mansion, has all the flair that Adora was expecting. There are enormous tents set up in a large, flat, unused horse pasture to house all the guests, lights strung from the ceilings, a stage set up for a band that's playing string versions of popular songs. It's all a far cry from the backbreaking work of being a stable groom and always having to work any time Fright Zone hosted any events.

They walk into one of the tents and see tables filled with people already, milling around and laughing loudly, some already probably drunk on the champagne that's being served. Adora's eyes scan the room.

She's not looking for Catra.

She's *definitely* not.

But then Bow is waving excitedly to someone in the crowd, and Adora turns to see—

Oh no.

Oh *no.*

She turns to see Catra.

Catra, in a suit, to be exact. Catra in a maroon suit with her hands in her pockets and an undone black bow-tie around her neck, and *fuck.* The bow-tie combined with Catra's hair up in a ponytail does nothing to distract Adora from staring at the expanse of Catra's neck, and Adora has to actually *shake* herself out of the rogue thought of running her teeth and tongue along Catra's collarbones.

Friends. She just wants to be friends. If that's even possible.

It'll be fine.

tll be *so* fine.

"Hey Catra!" Bow calls out, and Catra gives a small smile and takes one of her hands out of her pockets to wave back.

And then she's walking in Adora's direction.

Shit.

"Hey ," Catra greets once she reaches all of them, and then turns directly to Adora, who has her mouth clamped shut for no other reason than if she doesnt concentrate on that act alone, her jaw would drop wide open over how ridiculously *hot* Catra looks.

"Hey , Adora."

Adora suddenly feels the need to run a 5k. No, maybe a half-marathon. Because it's just not fair how the way Catra says *hey Adora* can still make her want to burst out of her skin after all this time. Catra still says it like it's a secret, like it's just for Adora and no one else, even when other people are around.

This is going to be a long night.

"Hi"—

But Glimmer cuts her off. "Bow and Iare going to go talk with Sea Hawk and Mermista. See you two later!"

"But"—

But Bow and Glimmer are already walking in the direction of the bar where their friends are sitting. Adora watches as Bow turns to give Adora a thumbs up and mouth something that looks like *you got this.*

She most certainly does not.

"She' s certainly not subtle," Catra mutters.

Adora smiles and lets out a small laugh. And then she feels trapped she's not really sure what she's allowed to say in this setting because here they are, alone, but definitely in a crowded room, and Adora doesnt want to make a scene or make Catra upset but she just—

But fuck, she doesnt know what else to say knowing that their last conversation ended with Catra running out a coffee shop.

It was just a stupid crush.

Adora tries not to think about that part either. Tries not to think about how that hurt way more than it should be allowed to.

It was just a stupid crush. And Adora's asking for a lot just wanting Catra's friendship back.

The last thing Adora needs to do is get any stupid, lingering feelings involved.

"Look, about yesterday—"

"It's fine," Catra says quickly, and in a way that Adora can easily tell that it's definitely not fine.

"No, it's not."

"Adora, we're trying to fix four years in the course of days. That's going to be overwhelming for anyone."

Of course it is. Even Adora feels overwhelmed by it all. Overwhelmed in the sense that there's so much that they need to talk about, and Adora's afraid they're somehow going to miss something and they'll fall apart all over again. But also overwhelmed in the sense that she's just relieved that Catra is even talking to her at all, that she's gotten even the smallest moments of feeling like the tension surrounding them isn't going to swallow them whole or choke them out.

"I can't help it. I just got excited."

It's the only way Adora can think to word it without accidentally saying *I actually really liked you too, and I was too stupid to tell you.*

"We were too close to just let things keep festering the way they have been," Adora adds.

Catra nods.

"I know."

Catra looks up at her and smiles softly, and it must make something in Adora's brain come loose because then another question is tumbling out of her mouth.

"So why self-sabotage like that?"

Catra bristles immediately and crosses her arms over her chest.

"Adora, now is really not the time or place."

Ideally, no, it's not. But then again—and Adora just can't help herself now—the little moments of normalcy, like they could be headed back to where they used to be after all this time, just almost feels addictive to Adora.

"Then when is?"

Catra stares back at her, mouth falling open slightly. And Adora stares right back, trying so hard to keep her fists clenched against her sides and not nervously cracking her knuckles or giving any indication with her body language that she's anxious.

Because really, when is good timing for them?

But the moment is broken swiftly, a reporter appearing at Catra's side and clearing their throat with an "excuse me." Catra seems to

recognize them right away when they ask for a few comments on Melog's training. She turns back to Adora.

"I have to take this," Catra answers. Expressionless. Unreadable.

And then she's walking away again.

Because of course. Parties and Catra walking away seem to go hand-in-hand.

Adora sighs, and then heads for the bar, where Bow and Glimmer are still talking to Seahawk and Mermista.

"How are things going?" Bow asks cautiously after he must overhear Adora order a drink.

Adora groans and answers from behind the curtain of her hands, her face pressed against her palms.

"Terrible!" she groans, mouth muffled behind her own hands before she finally moves them away. "Catra got whisked away for an interview as soon as I tried to talk to her."

"What were you trying to talk to her about?"

"I want to know why things fell apart like they did. I know what I did wrong and what was happening on my end, but there's still so much I don't know."

She doesn't know why Catra ran. Adora's always chalked it up to it being a drunken mistake, that Catra just got caught up in the heat of the moment, realized what she did, and ran. That maybe it just didn't mean anything at all, and Catra didn't see the need in bringing it up when Adora was about to leave anyway.

(Besides, it was apparently *just a stupid crush* anyway.)

And how could Adora possibly bring something like that up when she and Catra were barely speaking about Adora's leaving anyway?

When Catra left for a vacation and Adora left for her internship. When their goodbye was so awkward and cold, Catra silently helping Adora take the last of her boxes to a moving truck before choking out "take care" and barely looking at Adora with tear-filled eyes.

"And does she know your end of things?" Bow asks.

Adora doesn't even know how to begin. What is she going to say—*sorry I didn't kiss you back. You just surprised me.*

Sorry we never talked about me leaving or anything, but you wouldn't return my calls.

Sorry for leaving, but you broke my heart too.

"No. We haven't really had the chance to sit down and talk."

Adora can't come up with anything that doesn't start with her apologizing, even when she's not quite sure what she's apologizing for.

"Or when we do, she bolts," she adds.

She won't apologize for leaving, for going to vet school. But she's not even sure that Catra wants her to apologize for that—Adora just wants to *talk* to Catra so she can finally start to understand.

"What are you hoping to gain?" Bow asks, once Adora's drained the rest of her drink.

And that's a tricky question.

Because Adora knows what she would like to gain realistically. And then there's wildest dreams level. And she thinks (hopes) that maybe they'll land somewhere in the middle.

"What do you mean?"

Realistically, she thinks maybe they'll flounder through a conversation and end up cordial with each other, maybe hang out at Bow and Glimmer's wedding and the few other events they'll see each other at rather than avoiding each other.

Ideally , Adora would do the brave thing and be honest. She'd tell Catra that she never wanted to lose her and on top of that, actually always wanted more. Maybe still does.

"Oh, come on. You two have still been in each other's orbits for the past few years. This would have come up sooner or later with me and Glimmer getting married. So why now?"

Because the universe just won't stop pushing us back together.

Because seeing her again makes me remember how much I still care about her.

"Because I've already waited too long to try and say something," Adora says instead.

Bow keeps pressing in that balance of gentle and direct that he can so delicately strike. "What do you wanna say?"

So much, Adora thinks.

So much, and totally not enough.

"I just want my best friend back."

Even Bow doesn't seem to believe it when Adora says it. He stares at Adora, who makes a concerted effort not to make eye contact with Bow, staring at the ring of condensation that her glass has left on the wood of the bar.

Adora finally looks up when Bow sighs, and sees that his eyes have found Catra in the crowd again, watching her while she makes the same reporter who approached her laugh with one of her witty comments.

"You still really care about her, don't you?"

Adora's watching Catra laugh heartily, head thrown back and teeth poking out, looking carefree and light, and Adora remembers when she used to make Catra laugh like that.

"Never stopped," she replies, barely above a whisper.

Adora orders another drink and lets Bow lead her to their dinner table a few minutes later, trying (and failing) not to keep looking for Catra, eyes scanning the room for her.

She's pushing a cherry tomato around her salad plate when she feels a bump against her shoulder.

"You doing okay?"

Glimmer must have caught her staring, because Adora's still glancing over at Catra's table where she sits pristinely (tensely) while Shadow Weaver sits to her left.

"Yeah, I'm fine."

Glimmer nudges her shoulder again.

"You going to go say something, or just keep staring?"

And for as much as Glimmer pretends not to understand her and Catra's history, she sure seems to be intuitive to it, because Catra rises from her table, makes brief but direct eye contact with Adora, sighs, and then begins to walk away.

"What?!—

Her eyes follow Catra, who walks right out of the tent and disappears into the night.

Adora doesn't know if Catra means to look at her. Adora doesn't know if Catra even wants her to follow. But she's two drinks in and

even bolder and more reckless than usual. So she gets up quickly, clumsily knocking her chair back onto the grassy pasture beneath them, and follows Catra out of the tent.

It takes a moment for her eyes to adjust, no string lights brightening the outdoors, just a few ornate lamp posts and spotlights on the giant fountain in front of the house. Adora spies a silhouette at the base of the fountain, facing toward the water.

If Catra hears her approach, she doesn't show any signs of it, the roar of the fountain the only sound as the harsh harmony of clanging silverware with the chatter of the guests' voices fade out around them.

And Adora thinks of all the unanswered calls and texts. Adora thinks of all the things she's wanted to say. And she finally has Catra here and listening (hopefully).

So Adora dives in.

"You left after you kissed me, and then we never talked about it."

Adora sucks in a deep breath, like if she inhales sharply enough, she can swallow the words back up before they make their way to Catra's ears somehow.

But she sees Catra's ears perk up, watches as she stands up a little straighter. Adora keeps talking. She keeps talking because she's so damn tired of this in-between, and at least, if she lays it all bare here tonight and it goes horribly wrong, itll be better than whatever the last four years have been.

"I just assumed you thought it was a drunken mistake," Adora continues, half-hoping that her words are being lost entirely to the loud flow of the fountain.

But Catra turns around, eyes wide.

"Adora"—

"So I gave you some space while you were on vacation, and then you came back, and we just didn't speak."

Adora takes a step closer. Catra clenches her jaw.

"And then you left," Catra answers plainly.

There have been times in the past with Catra that Adora felt like she was trying to dig through rock—like there was no way she was ever going to break down Catra's walls. And she doesn't *want* to push her or pressure her—

But she doesn't know how else to show Catra that she still genuinely cares.

Adora nods at Catra's statement. Because it's true. It's factual. Adora left. But it's not the end of the story like Catra's finality in her tone seems to imply.

"And then I left, and I didn't know what I'd done wrong."

Adora keeps holding Catra's gaze, like if she just keeps looking at her, maybe she can fool Catra into thinking she's not completely freaking out on the inside. Like if she just keeps looking at her, maybe she can still get through to her.

"So I tried calling, I tried texting," Adora continues. "At one point I even thought about flying back to Bright Moon just to try and talk to you, but it was clear that you didn't want to talk to me, so I just"…

Catra's gaze falters, flickers toward the cobblestone underneath them. Adora keeps talking.

"I just tried to move on."

Adora dares to take another step closer, the roar of the fountain even louder now, but she's close enough to hear the shaky breath that

Catra takes in.

"And every time I saw you, it was like I was being pulled right back, but you always kept your distance, so"—

Another half-step closer.

This time Catra looks up, and Adora sees the tear-tracks on her face glistening in the lamplight.

"I didn't want to lose you by leaving, Cat."

Catra's bottom lip is quivering, and Adora watches as she tries to tuck it under her teeth to still it while she keeps watching Adora with glossy eyes. Adora's barely breathing as she waits for Catra to say something, *anything* at all.

"I'm sorry ," Catra says, breathily , barely audible over the fountain.

Oh.

"What?"

"I'm sorry . I'm sorry that I shut you out," Catra repeats, shaking her head and gulping in air to try and keep herself from fully sobbing.

Adora starts crying too, half out of relief that Catra's actually opening up and half out of sadness that it took so long just for Catra to get here and say that.

"After you told me you got into Eternia," Catra continues, "I started looking into barns I could work with in that area. I told Hordak, who of course, passed it on to Shadow Weaver."

Catra goes on to explain all the reminders that Shadow W eaver had given her over the years—she only kept her around because Adora got along with her. Shadow Weaver never saw Catra as anything other than a nuisance, a problem, despite what potential Hordak saw

in her. Years of being beaten down and still finding ways to prove herself beyond how Shadow Weaver belittled her.

"Catra"—

"And I believed it."

But its clear for that as much as Catra has succeeded professionally in spite of Shadow Weaver's abuse, it still stings somewhere deep.

"And then I kissed you, and I figured I had probably fucked everything up. I ran away , and I've been running away from that ever since."

Adora wants to pull her into a hug. Adora wants to rewind to four years ago and tell Catra to come with her, that she's better than Fright Zone and anything they have to of fer. Adora still wants to tell her that now.

"And I guess I just hoped that it would all fade out eventually ," Catra finishes with a shaky sigh.

"I thought you hated me," is all Adora can think to reply .

"I thought you hated me!"

And *god*, they are both so stupid. Adora doesn't stop the urge to lean forward and wrap her arms around Catra anymore, encircling her arms around her waist and pulling her close, Catra's face burrowing into Adora's shoulder.

She hasn't hugged Catra in four years, and having her this close again makes Adora burst into tears all over again.

"I never hated you," Adora whispers.

Adora holds her even tighter, reveling in how warm Catra feels pressed against her in the cool breeze of the night, stray drops of water from the fountain blowing and over and kissing Adora's

forehead. Having Catra this close is both a blessing and a curse because it makes her want to spill everything.

It seems to have the same effect on Catra as she answers, words slightly muffled by Adora's shoulder, "I figured there was no way you were ever going to feel the same way about me. So I just decided to shut you out and try and pretend it never happened."

Adora realizes she has two options.

1) She can let it go and focus on having Catra in her life again as her friend.

2) She can be brave. She can be honest. She can tell her.

And having Catra this close is both a blessing and a curse.

Because it makes Adora want to spill everything.

"Did it ever occur to you that I might have felt the same way?" Adora asks quietly, picking a focal point in the fountain and staring directly at it.

She feels Catra go rigid in her arms and then pull back suddenly, but still within Adora's reach with her hands gripping Adora's shoulders and her arms around Catra's waist.

"Did you?"

"I think I still do," Adora whispers.

The thing is, looking at Catra, Adora *knows* that she still feels that way. That she still wants more than what they had.

Catra's mouth opens, but the only sound that comes out is something that sounds like a muffled squeak. Her eyes are so wide in disbelief, like the idea that Adora could somehow possibly want her is still so foreign to her.

You idiot, Adora wants to say. *It's always been you.*

Catra's mouth finally moves, like she's finally going to say something, until Adora hears a voice from behind them.

"Catra! There you are!"

They break apart instantly , and Adora cranes her neck to see Entrapta, Scorpia, and Lonnie behind her as Lonnie says, "We've been looking for you all night!"

Adora turns back toward Catra, who's smiling and looking past Adora at her friends like they weren't just on the verge of some dramatic love confession years in the making. Adora smiles and waves at them when Scorpia gives her an excited hello.

Scorpia seems awfully sweet. So do the rest of Catra's friends.

But *shit*, they have terrible timing.

So Adora decides the best thing to do is bow out gracefully for now.

"I should go," she whispers, then nods toward Lonnie, Entrapta, and Scorpia before turning to walk back toward the party, to find Bow and Glimmer and get the hell out of here before she breaks down.

But as she goes, Adora feels a hand encircle her wrist and hold her in place. And then it slides down to grip her hand, squeezing it gently. Adora will tell herself that she knows it's Catra's hand before she sees it because logically, it's unlikely that any of these near-strangers would be holding Adora's hand. But truthfully, Adora knows that she somehow hasn't forgotten the spark that jumps through her body every time Catra would touch her. It's always been there~~in~~ playful punches to the shoulder in the barns, in shoves into hay bales, in lingering hugs, and yes, in Catra's hand tugging her along somewhere.

It's still electric.

And Adora feels her whole body set alight when she looks up into Catra's yellow-blue eyes, and she hears Catra say her goodbye softly.

"See you around, princess."

A corner of Catra's mouth quirks up in a smile, and when she lets go, Adora's hand suddenly feels too cold. When Catra walks away, Adora feels all the air in the space go with her.

Princess.

She hasn't heard Catra call her that in... she can't even remember how long.

Adora's jogging a horse around the track, making a clicking sound with her mouth to get them to speed up, going up into a posting trot as the mare extends her legs and runs faster, the gait becoming bouncier as she picks up speed.

Adora hears Catra's laughter before she sees her, cantering up besides her wide to her right on a young colt that Hordak has her helping desensitize to the starting gate.

"What, are you riding an English pleasure class over there?"

Adora rolls her eyes.

"Just warming up from here to the quarter pole, Catra."

"You're sitting that trot like a fucking princess," Catra shoots back, no malice behind the jab, her wide grin giving her away.

"I'm gonna kick your ass as soon as I get off this horse," Adora calls as Catra starts to pass her.

"Gonna have to catch me first, princess!"

And then Catra's taking off on the colt, quite literally leaving Adora in the dust.

The thing is, when she takes off, she takes Adora's heart with her.


sunflowerpaw





(THURSDAY – TWO DAYS BEFORE THE DERBY)

The thing about Derby week, Adora discovers, is that it causes highly successful adults to regress to their college days. Not that Adora's that far removed from that experience, but her ability to hold liquor the way she did in the height of her and Catra's junior and senior years has waned over time.

She definitely stopped going to parties in vet school.

She definitely didn't stop going to parties because they made her think of graduation.

Not at all.

But right now, she lets her legs dangle off a barstool while she drinks an expensive bourbon that D. Hope insisted she try (the same D. Hope who's now on the dance floor, getting way too close to a woman who Adora had overheard introduce herself as Mara). Nearby, a very drunk Bow barks out a laugh as he spins Catra around, Scorpia and her girlfriend Perfuma swaying their hips in time with the beat of the music next to them.

She can't help but watch Catra. Adora really hasn't been able to help herself all night—she's always been captivated by the way Catra moves. College was no different.

Really, the only reason she ever wanted Catra to teach her to dance was to give Adora an excuse to watch her .

They haven't spoken since last night, Catra leaving her with a squeeze of her hand that felt like a promise.

"I will never understand you two," Adora hears next to her , and turns to see Glimmer take a sip of her drink with a raised eyebrow.

Adora just turns back to the dance floor and pretends she hasn't heard her, still watching Catra as she throws her head back laughing, the muscles of her neck on full display with her hair pulled back in a ponytail.

Adora grips the glass tighter in her hand, welcoming the cool feeling of the ice cubes against her hand, against everything else in the room that's getting way too warm. Glimmer nudges her shoulder roughly, and Adora almost drops the glass.

"Hmm?"

Glimmer flickers her gaze very obviously between the dance floor and Adora, raising her eyebrows.

"She is a nightmare, Adora."

She smirks, knowing that Glimmer is only half-joking when she says it.

"She's not all that bad."

"You're just saying that because you used to sleep with her ," Glimmer quips.

Adora chooses the wrong time to take a sip from her drink, nearly choking on an ice cube when Glimmer says that.

"Glim, for the last time, we never slept together ."

But Glimmer, despite Adora having this conversation with her multiple times, seems unconvinced still. She gestures out to the dance floor and back to Adora, whose jaw has dropped slightly open when she sees Catra pull away from the group to dance with a stranger.

"The sexual tension between you two now could set off a seismic event. How the fuck have you two not boned?"

A question for the ages, Adora thinks to herself.

"And judging by the way she keeps looking over at you, I'd venture to say she wants to drag you the nearest bathroom," Glimmer adds.

"She does not—"

But at that exact moment, Catra turns around to find Adora staring at her and shoots her a sultry smile that Adora feels all through her body. Electric. Enough to set off a seismic event, in the words of Glimmer. And then Catra turns back around and starts making her way through the crowd with this stranger, away from where Adora can see her.

"Well, what are you waiting for?"

"You were just saying you think she's a nightmare."

Glimmer smiles and pats Adora on the shoulder. "To me, yes. But for whatever reason, my boyfriend seems to get along with her great, and she's a softie for you. Go dance."

But Adora cant find Catra in the crowd anymore, and she's nervous, and shell find any excuse to stay right here and just wait the night out glued to her barstool and not wading into completely uncharted territory with Catra.

"I think I need another drink first."

Adora orders and when she turns back around, she's able to find Catra again, now talking to a stranger who seems to be asking her something as the song changes, asking her to keep dancing. Adora grips the drink in her hand too tightly and hopes Glimmer doesnt hear her growl as Catra shrugs, and Adora can tell from reading her lips that she says, "sure."

Catra wraps her arms tentatively around the woman's shoulders and makes it a point to turn them so that Catra is facing Adora. So that Catra can stare directly at Adora while she dances. So that Catra can wink at Adora before turning her attention back to her dance partner.

"Might miss your chance, pal," Glimmer shouts over the noise of the music.

Adora sets her drink down with too much force and marches out toward the dance floor without a second thought because Catra is just messing with her now , begging her to make a move, it seems.

And that's another thing about Catra and Adora~~the~~y've always made each other braver, more reckless.

Adora intends to use it to her advantage now, still high off the feeling of holding Catra close last night and getting as close as she could to telling her how she feels.

Catra's eyes widen as she watches Adora approach, as she taps the shoulder of the woman Catra's dancing with, who turns around with an annoyed expression on her face.

"Mind if I cut in?" Adora grits out.

It's clear that the stranger does not want to get involved, and she must feel the tension in the air too as she takes her hands off Catra's hips and puts them up in surrender, nodding and wishing them a good night.

"Way to ruin my one chance at getting laid, Grayskull," Catra jokes, raising an eyebrow and crossing her arms.

She knows Catra's just messing with her. This is what Catra's always done—push and poke at all of Adora's buttons. It's just never been this high stakes. It's just never involved Adora realizing how much it bothers her seeing Catra with someone else.

"Oh, were you hoping I'd be watching for that too?" Adora deadpans.

Catra raises both eyebrows and smirks.

"You've been looking over at me all night," Adora adds.

Catra shrugs and rolls her eyes, replying, "Yeah, because I've been waiting for you to join us."

But there's a look in Catra's eyes that says there's more to it that she's not saying. There's a shift in the air around them. Everything feels heightened—from the way Catra leans in a little closer when she talks to the way Adora's balling her fists at her sides trying to resist the urge to grab Catra and kiss her in front of everyone at this party and leave no room for any other brave souls to dare ask to dance with her.

"Thought it might be a fun trip down memory lane. We used to put on such a show at parties," Catra adds.

"You seemed to be putting on enough of a show all by yourself tonight."

Catra barks out a laugh and puts her hands on her hips, asking, "What, are you jealous?"

"Why would I be jealous of a stranger who got to dance with you for two minutes when I've got years worth of memories of doing that with you?"

Catra's eyes scan Adora's face, and she waits, entire body tense and wanting to be closer to Catra, wanting to pull her in, wanting to stop fighting and dancing around each other. Catra puts the palms of her hands on Adora's shoulders and leans in, and everything feels like its on fire as Catra comes closer.

"Dance with me," she whispers in Adora's ear.

Catra pulls away again, hands sliding down to graze over Adora's collarbones before falling back to her sides, and Adora thinks she might actually *die* from the way Catra's looking at her.

"Oh come on, She-Ra. Grayskull. Get that annoying weight of the world on your shoulders look off your face for one night."

Catra tosses a smirk back at Adora and turns so that she's facing away from her, swaying her hips right in front of her. Adora's mouth goes dry. Her hands just hang loosely, awkwardly in the space between her and Catra. The space that's diminishing because Catra is slowly scooting her way back toward Adora.

Surely, Catra's just drunk. Surely it has nothing to do with the angry tension from the last several days that's seemed to morph into something else entirely tonight. Something that was simmering all throughout college and has set itself alight now that Adora's told Catra how she felt.

And then Catra is grabbing at Adora's wrists, tugging her forward, and sliding her palms over the tops of Adora's hands as Catra rests them on her hips.

"You can put your hands on me, you know," Adora barely hears her say over the noise. "Nothing we haven't done before."

Adora can't tell if the pounding in her head is her own heartbeat or the bass of the music.

The song changes then, something slower, and with it, the sway of Catra's hips slow under Adora's hands.

Okay.

So the fast pounding is definitely her heartbeat.

Adora wonders if she's about to pass out when Catra presses back even more until her ass is up against Adora's front—

Good *god.*

Catra grinds back into her, and Adora thinks she might actually collapse as she digs her fingers into Catra's hips, thumbs grazing over the small of her back in a way that rucks up the fabric of her shirt until Adora feels soft, bare skin over her fingertips. Catra's singing along to the chorus of the song that plays until she gasps at the feel of Adora's hands.

It feels like they've always been heading toward this.

And the feeling gets even stronger when Catra runs a hand up Adora's neck, gently scratching all the way up and tangling that hand in Adora's hair, her other hand coming to rest on one of Adora's hands on her hips.

Adora's forehead presses against the back of Catra's neck.

"Cat"—

Adora mumbles it into Catra's shoulder. The heat from Catra's neck pressing into Adora's forehead is suddenly replaced by a cold draft of air, and Adora lifts her head to feel and see Catra spinning around in her arms.

And suddenly her face is way too close.

"Hmm?" Catra asks, smirking most likely at the way Adora's mouth is hanging open. "Cat got your tongue?"

Adora's brain has short-circuited, she thinks. She tries to speak but nothing's coming out.

"You are too easy sometimes, Adora."

"If this is the kind of dancing we did in college, you and I must remember things very differently," Adora finally says, but the words feel distant and like she's not even in control of her own mouth anymore.

Catra smiles even wider and leans closer again.

"I'm just doing all the things I wished I'd been brave enough to."

"You're killing me, Cat."

Adora's voice is rough, strangled, and she can't really see anything in the crowded club through the buzz of the alcohol and Catra's yellow and blue eyes this close and burning into her. There's technicolor lights and loud music and the bass is beating quickly in time with Adora's heartbeat.

It's all a blur with Catra smirking at her, arms looped loosely around Adora's neck while she keeps swaying to the beat, her hips moving like she's the one in control of Adora's hands that grip tightly to Catra's hips. Like Adora's just a puppet with her strings attached to Catra's body.

And then Catra cuts the thread, backs away and out of Adora's arms.

"Well, *this* has been fun," Catra says with the biggest smirk.

Adora's breathless, and Catra is still so close—just out of her reach and smiling with a fang poking out from between her lips like she knows Adora's a complete *goner.*

"But what"—

I've got five horses on the work tab tomorrow starting at six," Catra yells over the cheers of the crowd as a new song comes on. "Need my beauty rest if I'm gonna be facing the cameras with a hangover."

And then Catra's leaning closer again, hands tangling in Adora's jacket and tugging her in and *oh my god*—

Catra stares right at Adora's lips and tilts her head to the left, lips pressed close to the shell of Adora's ear.

Adora can practically hear the grin in her voice rather than see it.

"Good night, Ms. Grayskull."

And with that, Catra's hands fall away. Her lips and her warmth are gone, turning quickly on her heel and walking away.

Leaving Adora in the middle of a crowded dance floor, dazed and confused.

Yeah.

Just like college.

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(FRIDAY—ONE DAY BEFORE THE DERBY)

Catra does, indeed, wake up with a headache. Not as bad as she was anticipating, but a steady, pounding reminder of the night before nonetheless. And it shows no signs of going away when she arrives back at the barn after a dismal workout from Melog to find a frantic Scorpia, who informs her that one of the horses is injured. Because of course things start to unravel the *day before* the Derby.

Which means she'll have to talk to Adora.

Which means she'll have to *see* Adora.

There's less of a feeling of dread in the knot in her stomach that twists when she thinks of Adora and more of a tension that sits low and is woven with anticipation—and nerves. A lot of nerves. Because it feels like since the Bright Moon gala, since Adora actually stood before her and asked if it had ever occurred to Catra that *she might feel the same*, something's snapped.

Like they're hurtling toward something that's been sitting latent for years, just waiting for the right spark to set it all ablaze.

She's terrified—terrified of being vulnerable, of putting herself in a position where she could maybe get hurt again.

And then she thinks of Adora's *stupid* eyes and her *stupid* face, looking at her with so much sincerity, and Bow's *she makes you softer*—

"Hey, I got your text. What's up?"

Catra whirls around to see Adora, arms crossed and wearing a tight white button-up with her sleeves rolled up to the elbows.

Suddenly, Catra's headache is much worse.

She groans and turns away from Adora, leaning down next to the injured horse's leg.

"This horse is lame as shit on his left front. Scorpia took him out of his stall this morning to get him ready for a gallop, and he's barely putting weight on it. He won't let either of us touch it."

Adora leans down next to her, and maybe, if Catra weren't so agitated by the fact that she's having to deal with this setback and wondering why Melog looked so sluggish this morning while Adora is

crouching on the ground beside her and looking like *that*, this would be a more pleasant morning.

"So what, you brought me out here so I could get cow kicked instead?"

Catra stands up again and can't help but reach out a hand to help Adora up as well.

Which is a stupid idea.

Because anytime she's touched Adora in the last few days, she feels like she might spin out of control completely. Like she might do something stupid like kiss her again.

"Yes, that about sums it up."

Adora leans against the barn wall, and Catra tries to ignore the way Adora's crossed arms and the positioning of Adora's hands only serve to accentuate her biceps.

"Might just be an abscess," Adora says, looking down at the horse's hoof where he only points a toe into the ground.

"Doesn't fucking matter if it's just an abscess. He's still out of the Turf Classic tomorrow."

She *knows* she shouldn't be taking this out on Adora. She knows that she can't make Adora her punching bag. But she's exhausted and annoyed that the reason she barely slept last night is because she was up thinking of Adora.

Did it ever occur to you that I might have felt the same way? and *I think I still do* are playing on a loop in Catra's head and have been ever since the other night, much to the detriment of her sleeping patterns.

Because what does she do with that? Where do they even go from here? Grinding against Adora on a crowded dance floor the night

before doesn't really give her as many answers to that as she'd like.

"Better this one than Melog?" Adora asks tentatively, like she's trying to find the bright side of the situation.

Catra softens just a bit, briefly playing into Adora's light-hearted attempt at making the best of it by dramatically gasping and covering the horse's ears.

"Adora, how dare you!"

Adora only rolls her eyes and hands Catra the lead rope that's hanging next to the stall door.

"Can you hold him while I take a look?"

Catra clips the lead rope to the horse's halter and carefully leads him out into the barn aisle, Adora helping steady him as he limps out. Adora gently pets the horse, scratching at his neck and shoulder and waiting for him to let out a heavy sigh through his nostrils before gently petting down his leg and carefully picking up his foot, trying carefully to hold it still when he tries to jerk away.

Adora's always had this gentle strength about her, this persistence that threads its way through her work as well as how she is with Catra. Pushing, but never forceful. Present, but never demanding.

Catra wonders if she's ever going to forgive herself for the way she pushed Adora away. She thinks that's what she's most frustrated about that Adora's not holding this against her more. That Adora just wants to be close to her again and instead of pushing Catra away right back, pulls her back in.

"Definitely an abscess," Adora says and places the horse's hoof back on the ground while she rummages around for some supplies.

"What are you doing?"

"Uh I'm gonna flush it and clean it."

And while Bow is right, that Adora does make her softer, soft is not what she needs right now when she has a steadily growing to-do list. But she also doesnt need Adora to clean up her messes. She can handle the abscess just fine.

"I know how to treat an abscess, Adora. I can do it myself," Catra snaps.

She's *so* fucking bad at this.

"It's my job, Catra," Adora snaps back, clearly confused at the way Catra's acting.

Part of her wishes Adora would be angrier at her. Like its not enough that Catra pushed her away for years, like there needs to be more consequences.

It cant just be that easy.

She cant just get to have Adora after all this time.

And the voice in her head that reminds her of all these things sounds eerily like Shadow Weaver, only adding to Catra's frustration.

"And I'm sure it's also your job to go rub shoulders with all of Bright Moon's finest, so I'm sure your time would be better spent over there checking out Swift Wind or something."

Adora furrows her brow and throws her arms out to the side, clearly growing exasperated with Catra.

"What is wrong, Catra?"

"Nothing!" Catra shouts. "I just dont want your help with something so small. You've seen me help clean abscesses before."

"Fine! If you dont want my help, I'll get out of your hair. If you dont want to tell me what the problem is, fine."

Adora sighs, giving Catra a pleading look, before turning away and reaching for the box of vet supplies she's carried in with her. Catra tangles a hand in the horse's mane to ground herself.

"My problem is that I am running on four hours of sleep, Melog looked completely off the bridle this morning, the day before the Derby, and you show up here wearing that shirt that has no *fucking* business making your arms look that good."

It shouldn't be this easy to have Adora close to her again. It shouldn't be this easy to say things like that to Adora.

She makes you softer. Hold onto that, okay?

Adora looks up suddenly, vet supplies suddenly forgotten and eyes wide like she tries (and fails miserably) to suppress a wide smile.

"You're snapping at me because of my muscles?"


My problem i
that I'm on four hour of sleep,
Melog looked
'tly off the bridle this morning,
the day befo
the Derby,
and YOU sho
up here! Wearing that shirt that has NO FUCKING
business mak
your arms look
that goal!


Soo... You're snapping at me...
because of my muscles?

Adora bursts out laughing, like that's the funniest thing Catra could have possibly said and not one of the many sources of Catra's frustration.

"No! Shut up."

Catra turns away from Adora and tries to hide her blush by moving behind her horse's face, rubbing his velvet nose and pretending she doesn't want Adora to stay.

She hears Adora sigh and then watches as she walks around the horse, reaching up to pet the horse's neck and putting her hand dangerously close to where Catra's is.

Something's snapped, like they're hurtling toward something that's been sitting latent for years, just waiting for the right spark to set it all ablaze. And everything feels like it's been on fire for the past two days.

"Look, you can either stay and hold this horse or you can tie him in his stall and ask Scorpia to help me. Your call, Catra."

She doesn't *want* to run from Adora anymore.

She's just so used to it that she's not even sure what the other option looks like anymore.

But Adora's just watching her, patiently, waiting for Catra to decide.

Catra carefully backs the horse up and walks him back to his stall. Adora's face falls as Catra emerges from the stall again.

"I guess I'll see you—"

She doesn't let Adora finish. Instead, she reaches forward, hands tangling in Adora's hair. And Catra presses her lips against Adora's

before she can think about it too much.

This time, Adora doesn't hesitate to kiss her back. Her hands quickly slide to Catra's hips and hold her tightly, a moan escaping her mouth as Catra seeks to deepen the kiss, and any stupid doubts that Catra had in her mind go quiet just for a moment because this time Adora is kissing her back just as eagerly.

But it doesn't last long, and Catra pulls back suddenly—another apology, an explanation, *something* on her lips because she's second-guessing herself again,maybe this was a mistake after all, and what if this ruins everything—

But Adora's eyes are dark and completely focused on Catra, and she doesn't get to finish the thought because her brain goes quiet, completely surrounded by Adora, when she feels her hands slide from her hips down to her thighs, and Adora hoists her up and presses her against the barn wall, pulling her in for a searing kiss.

Chapter End Notes

part three will be out sometime in the next week or so, and then i will return to ewb, my beloved. i appreciate everyone's patience as i'm trying very hard to post in a timely manner but also, life gets in the way a lot. :)

side note, this fic has a playlist.

comments are always appreciated.

home stretch

Chapter Summary

> catra goes from "this is not because i like you" to "are you SURE you like me?" bow is a good friend. adora does some vet work. melog runs a race.

Chapter Notes

> me when i started big bang: this is going to be like a 12k oneshot.
> me now: this is a 3-part, 30k fic now i guess.
>
> welcome to the final chapter of horse girl summer! thanks to all of you who have been reading and especially to those who have commented and shared their thoughts with me on the fic. i apologize for the delay in updates. i've been pretty exhausted and while writing is a hobby first and foremost, i'd be lying if i didn't say it has felt like a chore for a little while.
>
> i once again want to shoutout my two big bang artists, pau and aura, and once again want to remind you that you can find them on twitter @blackcleryberry_ and @sunflowerpau__!
>
> again: i wrote a song to go with this fic! it's called "long shot" and its based on catra's point of view. you can listen to that here, and while you're there, feel free to listen to my other stuff!
>
> also, for those of you who were expecting smut, i regret to inform you that it's not ewb-level, but...its still something lol.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's not quite sure how something that's been building slowly for so long can actually live up to the hype, but the feel of Adora's lips charting a course down her neck right to her pulse point feels

impossibly good. Maybe it would have broken the spell that Adora's had over her for so long if she just turned out to not be a good kisser or something.

But unsurprisingly, Adora, who is good at most things, proves to be absolutely fantastic at pulling all kinds of reactions from Catra with the way her body feels pressed up against hers, the feel of her hands gripping tightly against the backs of her thighs, holding her against the barn wall, how her lips are so soft against Catra's own.

"Wow," Adora mumbles, after releasing her mouth from Catra's neck and pressing her forehead into Catra's.

"Fuck," is the only remotely coherent thing that Catra can utter.

She's completely wrapped up both literally and figuratively in Adora, and she barely remembers that they're in the middle of Catra's barn when Adora nudges the collar of Catra's shirt aside and starts kissing more of the exposed skin where her neck and shoulder meet.

It's intoxicating that's the only way Catra can think to describe it. Now that she's had this part of Adora, even just for a few minutes, she's hooked. It's one of the few things that's been able to get all the racing thoughts in her head to finally just *quiet*, and all Catra wants is more of that. More peace. More quiet. More Adora.

But they're also in the middle of the barn. And unfortunately, it's not actually quiet, and Catra can hear the sounds of people's voices on the other side of the shedrow, and it's likely that someone will show up and interrupt them because isn't that just how it goes—

"Adora, stop"—

Adora pulls her head back quickly, releasing Catra's neck with a popping sound, and her cheeks are so flushed, and she has this dazed look in her eyes that just makes Catra want to pull her back in. Adora's breathtaking, and it should be something that Catra finds

annoying and frustrating until she remembers that in moments like these, she really doesn't have to.

"Someone might see us," Catra adds quickly, more to remind herself than to tell Adora.

Adora blushes even deeper, clearing her throat and carefully setting Catra back onto the ground. Catra holds onto Adora's shoulders because she's not sure she can stand properly if she lets go yet.

"Right. Right. I'm sorry. I got—"

Adora stares down at Catra's lips again.

"A little carried away."

Catra's heart stutters as she feels more than sees Adora start to lean in again. She looks like she's about to lean forward to capture her lips again, and Catra's powerless to stop her, gripping her nails into Adora's shoulders just to give herself something to be anchored to.

"Catra! Adora!"

But Adora jolts backward, nearly knocking Catra in the forehead as she does as Lonnie calls out their names from down the hall. Catra quickly slides her hands off of Adora's shoulders as she stumbles backward and slips onto the barn floor.

Adora lands on her ass in a pile of hay that must have fallen out of someone's hands this morning when they were feeding the horses.

"Lonnie! Hi! How are you? Wow, that was that?"

Adora greets her in a high-pitched, frenetic voice, laughing nervously and quickly rising to her feet (and then nearly falling over again), brushing the grassy strands off her pants.

"Hay, Adora," Catra answers, one eyebrow raised and a smirk on her face. "You tripped over hay."

t’ s annoyingly cute~~the~~ way Adora quickly clears her throat and sidesteps away from Catra and Lonnie to where the barn opens up toward the parking lot, pretending to be looking through the bed of her vet truck for supplies. t’ s so cute, and Catra hates that knowing that she can reduce Adora to a stammering mess who trips over things. t sends all kinds of adrenaline through her body , and that just feels like too much power for one person to have.

“Entrapta was looking for you. Something about Melog’ s aerodynamics,”Lonnie says, turning toward Catra.

And then Lonnie starts walking away to lead to Catra toward Entrapta, but not before she glances toward Adora, then back at Catra, and winks.

Catra fights the growing urge to pull her hair out of its ponytail and try and cover her face with it, desperate to hide the way she knows her cheeks are probably burning red.

“Of course. Ill be right there,”Catra answers quickly , giving Lonnie a pointed look and a flick of her wrist telling her that shell follow in just a moment.

Lonnie smirks and turns away, slowly walking toward the end of the barn, waiting for Catra to follow. Meanwhile, Adora is still rummaging aimlessly through the truck, and Catra finds her pretending to be staring at the packaging of a syringe. Catra taps her on the shoulder. Adora nearly jumps as she spins around.

“Scorpia will be right over ,”Catra says. “ve gotta go.”

“Right. The abscess,”Adora replies, nodding fervently and her words coming out almost breathlessly.

And now, here, in the actual quiet, with just her and Adora and no one else around them anymore (except for the horses), Catra feels the hot, tight coils of panic wrapping around her throat again. In the aftermath, Catra finds herself, out of instinct, wanting to claw back

into the place they were before—the one where she didn't know what Adora's tongue feels like against hers and the one where Adora's kissed her back.

She wants to crawl back into the place where she didn't have to be vulnerable. Because suddenly, while the barn is deadly quiet, Catra's mind is not.

Because now she's had Adora like this—wrapped up in Catra and staring at her like she is right now, like she wants to pick Catra up and put her in the passenger seat of her truck and drive her back to her apartment.

And because of that, it means Adora's something, some*one*, she can lose. Someone she can lose in a way that might hurt worse than before.

And that? Well, that feels like a little much for Catra to process when she has a Derby horse to worry about for tomorrow.

So she ignores the way Adora's still staring at her, gaze wandering down to Catra's lips again, and steps out of the small space between them.

"I should go," Catra says, before she turns and follows Lonnie down the hall, her heart feeling like it's going to beat out of her chest.

She doesn't give Adora time to answer, just keeps her eyes fixed on Lonnie waiting at the end of the hall, and goes to talk with Entrapta.

The conversation with Entrapta doesn't take long, and by early afternoon, Catra's feeling as calm as she thinks she might be able to on the day before such a big race. She's avoiding Shadow Weaver and any comments that she might have to make about Melog's slow gallop this morning, but looking at the horse now, Catra can't find a hair out of place. He's in his stall, dozing off in the corner, and seeing his head drooping down with the bottom of one hind leg curled in relaxation, makes Catra feel like she can finally take a breath.

She's done everything she can. Whether or not Shadow Weaver will see that depending on the result tomorrow, remains to be seen.

But Catra knows deep down that she's done everything she can.

And it's what she has to keep repeating to herself every time the stray thoughts of *you're a nuisance* and *you'll still never amount to anything* and *this is where you peak and you'll never get this far again* poke their way into her mind.

But that gets more difficult as the day goes on and as Catra gets more tired, energy sapped from the throngs of people she's surrounded by as she sends three horses out in different races throughout the day. She's exhausted, and by the time the last spectator has left and all of Catra's charges are back in their stalls with their dinner, she feels pushed around by these thoughts, knocked in the shoulders like she was earlier by the crowds of people making their way through the stands.

You're only holding Adora back.

This one seems to be the most prevalent, complete with a taunting tone that only Shadow Weaver can accomplish. Catra plays it on a loop all afternoon and into the evening until she's left standing at the rail once again.

She makes you softer, she hears again in Bow's voice.

And its those two thoughts that go back and forth, warring until she finally pulls out her phone to text someone who she knows might be able to talk her down.

Bow meets her at their spot twenty minutes later, perched in front of track, the eighth pole staring her down from across the sandy surface on which the horses run. Catra holds her head in her hands as Bow leans on his forearms on the rail and sighs.

"What are you—"

"Shhh."

Catra presses her palms more tightly against her face, the heels of her hands digging into her eye sockets until its almost painful. And she feels so fucking stupid that it's the day before the Derby and rather than panicking about the race, she's panicked about *Adora.*

"Catra, what is going on?" Bow asks, this time poking a finger against Catra's forearm. Catra knows it's a warning sign before he probably attempts to pry her hands away from her face if she doesnt do it herself. Because Bow's one of the few people who can get away with that without getting his own eyes clawed out.

So much.

There is so much going on.

But at the heart of it all, at the heart of Catra's fear that she's *just not good enough*, like Shadow Weaver has remined her all these years, she's stuck on the fact that she just might not be good enough for Adora.

"I may or may not have kissed Adora," Catra finally mutters, staring straight ahead at the tractor that slowly rolls over the track, raking the sands and combing through the surface until its neat once again, no trace of hoofprints from the day's last race, like it's some giant zen garden.

She doesnt look at Bow, just hears the small gasp he fails to suppress when Catra says it.

Then, a pause. Like he's waiting for more.

"Like today? Like just now?" Bow finally asks when Catra doesnt continue.

Catra finally tears her eyes away from the machine, chin resting on her fists and fingers reaching up to try and cover part of her face

again.

"Oh my god. What"—

"She came by to look at one of the horses, and I just—snapped."

Snapped. Exploded. Cracked. Under enough pressure, things come apart. They come undone. And under all that pressure, how could Catra *not* kiss her?

(Even if it is the main source of her anxiety now.)

"Well, what happened?"

Catra replays the moment in her head and still wonders if maybe she dreamed it, if it wasn't just some silly false memory her brain formed in the middle of the night while still trying to rid itself from the buzz of the alcohol the night before. But it feels too real. And she knows how Adora's lips felt. And how she lifted Catra so fucking effortlessly and —

It's all real. And it's all Catra can think about. And Adora's all she wants.

And that's dangerous.

"She kissed me back," Catra replies plainly, shrugging while she says it like she's trying not to make a big deal of it.

(Even though it is, in fact, a huge fucking deal.)

"So what are you doing here, exactly?"

Bow is staring at Catra like her one professor did during her sophomore year equine business class when Catra blurted out an answer to a question that was so completely wrong (to be fair, it was the one time all semester Catra hadn't been paying attention. The *one time*).

"What?" Catra asks.

Bow throw his arms up in the air, clearly exasperated.

"What are you doing here? Go talk to her!"

"I—

t' s the logical choice. The smart choice, really . And she brought Bow here because Catra knew that's exactly what he would recommend.

And it's also the vulnerable choice. Which inherently makes it harder.

Bow groans, and its his turn to throw his head in his hands.

"Y ou two are going to kill me and Glimmer. I mean that literally ."

Catra laughs but it fades out quickly . She's *so* stuck on the thought that she's not enough, *so* fixated on the chance that maybe Adora didnt actually mean it…

And once again, Catra remembers that she's been running for so long that she forgets that she has other options.

"What if she just did it on instinct? Like what if—"

She shouldnt even be voicing the thought. She shouldnt be seeking reassurance from Bow like this, but she's so anxious all the sudden, the weight of the day slamming into her from the top of her head to her shoulders and all the way down her body, like Catra might actually melt into the concrete beneath her if she doesnt hold herself up against this rail.

She's so tired. And she's so tired of running. But making any other choices feels exhausting too.

"Oh my god. W alk me through what happened."

So Catra does. She explains it all, from the dancing (which Bow gently reminds her that he and everyone else in the bar saw very clearly), to waking up this morning and going to the barn to the abscess to that stupid moment of weakness (or strength and bravery Catra still can't decide), to finally remembering that she has a choice. That she doesn't have to run from Adora anymore.

(Even if she's having trouble reminding herself of that now.)

"Adora pressed you up against a wall, and you're here telling me about it instead of finding her and getting your crap together."

The look Bow is leveling Catra with now is one of utter exhaustion. Catra wonders if he and Glimmer were in this position, if she would feel just as annoyed as Bow surely does right now.

"That about sums it up, yes," Catra replies simply.

Bow places his hands on Catra's shoulders and guides her to turn around, facing away from the track and toward the vast expanse of the empty seats of the grandstand. Toward the exit. Toward the barns.

Toward Adora.

"Go. Now."

Catra whirls around again with a sound of protest, but Bow doesn't let her speak. He just shakes his head and gives her a firm stare, crossing his arms and standing anchored to the ground.

He's not going to let Catra get out of this.

But even though she might not completely feel it right now, she is grateful for the push.

Because she needs the accountability.

Catra's not even sure where Adora could be right now, if she's at home or still working or wandering around somewhere with Glimmer or any of their other friends. But if she's going to do this, if she's going to face Adora again, she needs to stop somewhere else first.

Because it's the day before the Derby , and the sun is setting, and she's so tired.

And something Catra's always appreciated about horses is the way they see right through people.

So Catra shuffles back to the barn and immediately heads toward Stall 22, where Melog stands with his head and neck out the door, ears perking up when he sees her coming. He lets out a low nicker and points his nose toward Catra in hopes that hell be greeted with a treat. Catra smiles and lets him gobble up a peppermint out of her hand before she wraps her arms around his neck and lets out a deep sigh.

Everything goes quiet. Just for a moment.

Catra finally lets go of Melog, who just stares at her with dark, wide eyes and perked ears.

"This is so fucking stupid," she whispers, to no one except the horse.

And then, since no one else is around to hear, she asks the question that's been rattling around in her head all day.

"What if Adora doesnt want me like I want her?"

And again, something Catra's always appreciated about horses is the way they see right through people.

Because suddenly Melog nudges her stomach with his nose, hard enough that it forces Catra to back up, and then the horse is lifting his head high, his attention clearly caught by something.

And when Catra turns, she sees what it is.

Or who, rather.

"Adora."

Adora's stepping out of her vet truck and shutting the door quickly, rounding the back of the vehicle panting like she's been running around the track all day.

And Adora greets Catra with a beaming smile when she sees her.

"I've been looking for you," she says breathlessly.

Oh.

And then Adora is staring at Catra with the same hungry look in her eyes from earlier, the same one that was the final push Catra needed to just *shut up* and let herself be happy for a damn minute. Catra feels it again, more of a pull this time, tugging her into Adora's orbit despite the nagging *but what if* that's been plaguing her mind all day, trying to keep her tethered to the same place she's been stuck for the past four years.

You'll never be enough for her, she hears again.

Did it ever occur to you that I might feel the same way? Catra hears in response this time.

"Adora, what—"

"Let's not think about it so hard."

And Catra thinks that might be the smartest thing she's ever heard this beautiful, brilliant woman say. Because Adora is quickly closing in on her and wrapping her up again, leaving no doubt in Catra's mind anymore. Adora's fingertips skate across Catra's cheeks on their way to tangle in her hair, and she's pulling her in again, just like she did this morning, lips slotting against Catra's.

She makes you softer. Hold onto that, okay?

Catra holds on.

She holds on tight.

Catra finds that Adora kisses with the same gentle strength she sees her use in her work, the same gentle strength she's always had with Catra. She feels Adora's tongue slide against her bottom lip and not push further. Waiting, asking, wanting. Present, but never demanding. And Catra gives in to the feeling, deepening the kiss and reveling in the feel of Adora's hands dragging down from her hair and face to her hips while Catra wraps her arms around Adora's neck.

Catra pulls back to take a breath and mumbles Adora's name against her lips.

"Do you have any idea how long I've wanted to do this?" Adora whispers back, punctuating the question with a quick kiss to Catra's lips.

"What—"

Catra cuts herself off though, wanting to hear more of what Adora has to say. She just wants to hear Adora say more things that only remind Catra that *yes*, she does in fact want Catra.

And now, being here like this and actually seeing the way Adora's responding to her, the way every time Catra pulls, Adora only follows willingly—

"I am such an idiot."

"We both are," Adora answers with a gentle laugh that Catra wants to hear over and over again.

Adora pulls her closer again, lips pressing to Catra's mouth, to her cheeks, her chin, her jaw, and then down her neck again. And where things got interrupted when they started to get more…*heated* earlier,

there's no one around now to stop Adora from grazing her teeth gently into the muscle of Catra's neck and sucking a bruise into her skin there. The moan Catra lets out in response is something she'd be embarrassed by if she cared enough, but all she can think about is how good it feels—

And then Adora's confidently sliding a hand up the front of Catra's shirt when she hears a horse sneeze down the hallway, and Catra remembers where they are.

"Adora"—

But it comes out in a breathy way that seems to accidentally encourage Adora rather than stop her, and Catra is almost too far gone to keep trying.

"Adora, stop," she finally stammers out.

Adora's off her immediately, stepping back and out of Catra's space in surprise, blue eyes wide, strands of hair starting to spring out of her ponytail, plush lips parted and cheeks flushed.

God, she's beautiful.

"As much as I want to do this, I don't know that fucking in an empty horse stall is a good idea," Catra explains.

Adora just nods, clearly still dazed from what's happened.

"Right."

Adora's eyes are once again darting between Catra's eyes and lips, like she's still trying to process what the perils of having sex in a semi-public place would be.

"Maybe another time, though?"

Adora's eyes fly back up to Catra's eyes, and she frowns.

"Oh."

"I mean for fucking in a barn."

Catra feels her face heat up as she says it, eyes fixed firmly to a stack of straw bedding bales off to the side. She wants to look anywhere but Adora's face because shit, she is bad at this, and even though Adora is probably frowning because she thinks Catra means that she doesn't want this to go any further, Catra can't help the spike of anxiety that makes her stomach twist.

"The fucking part can still—"

Catra stops herself, awkwardly grabbing at the back of her neck with her hand and still looking away from Adora because she has no idea how to finish the sentence. No idea how to actually say what she wants.

"Shit, no wonder we didn't speak for four years. I suck at communicating," Catra mutters.

"You're just realizing that?" Adora answers with a wry smile.

Catra only rolls her eyes and asks herself what she's so afraid of—truly, she's already done the hardest part. Right? If she could muster up the courage to kiss Adora earlier, then surely, she can do this.

She can keep being vulnerable.

She has that choice.

"I take it your apartment probably isn't an option."

Adora shakes her head. The last thing either of them probably want is for Bow and Glimmer to walk in on them.

"My hotel's a ten-minute drive from here," Catra adds, and then holds her breath while the time it takes for Adora to answer seems to stretch on for minutes.

In reality, it's maybe two seconds before Adora breaks into a wide smile.

"Lead the way."

Catra climbs into the passenger seat of the vet truck, and the ride is silent except for Catra giving Adora directions to her hotel. She tries and fails multiple times to still her leg that keeps bouncing anxiously as Adora sighs every time they hit a stop light.

It's tense. But not in the way it used to be.

It's not the tension that Catra would dread every time Adora walked into a room or came near her. Not even the same tension that sat heavy in the booth with them at the coffee shop a few days ago, the tension that felt like impending disaster. This is the kind of tension that feels like a beginning.

The drive usually takes Catra ten minutes.

Adora does it in seven.

It's a quiet (and brisk) walk through the parking lot, to the elevator, where they have to wait an annoyingly long time for it to arrive, and then even more annoying when an older couple joins them and asks Catra to hit the button for the eighth floor after she hits her button for the fifth.

But Catra thinks that if her biggest complaint right now is that she doesn't get to make out with Adora in an elevator, then she's doing pretty well.

(And she can file that away for another time and place.)

Catra nearly pulls Adora off her feet grabbing her by the wrist and leading her the short walk down the hallway to her room. She barely gets her key card out and has the door open before Adora grabs her by the hips again and presses her against the door as it closes.

But she doesn't lean forward.

She doesn't start kissing Catra's neck and doesn't lift Catra off the ground.

Adora smooths the loose strands of hair out of Catra's face and scans her eyes for any uncertainty, looking at her so softly that it makes Catra want to cry.

"You're sure about this?"

You're not good enough for her.

But Adora is staring at her like she's more than enough, and Catra makes the choice to believe it.

"Adora, I've been thinking about this for much longer than I'd like to admit. Yes, I'm sure."

Catra leans in first this time, Adora kissing her back gently at first, softer and slower.

"You are so beautiful," Adora says when she breaks away from Catra for just a moment before leaning back in to press another kiss to the corner of Catra's mouth.

Catra hums against Adora's lips when she kisses her again, this one with a little more heat behind it. Like it has the intention of leading somewhere further. Catra sighs into it.

"And it's really not fair that you've somehow gotten hotter in the last four years."

"You thought I was hot in college?"

Adora pulls back and for some reason, seems surprised by this development, and Catra just groans and responds, "Of course~~ of~~ course I did, dummy."

Catra pushes off against the door and starts walking Adora backward into the room while Catra reaches for Adora's jacket an old, red thing that she's had since college that she really wishes she would get rid of and shrugs it off. Catra slides her hands up Adora's arms and squeezes.

"And these stupid muscles have been driving me crazy for years."

Adora responds with another wide smile and says, "Everything about you has been driving me crazy for years."

Catra laughs, and while she's not sure she completely believes it (yet), she wants to.

"Do you have any idea how seeing you in that damn suit made me feel?" Adora continues.

"Oh, you liked that?"

Catra starts plucking the buttons of Adora's shirt free of their holds while she kisses Catra's neck again, teeth and tongue against her skin clearly with the intention of leaving more marks.

"You—"

Adora pauses and presses a kiss to Catra's jaw, tugging on the bottom of her shirt and lifting it over Catra's head.

"are incredibly sexy."

Catra shivers, partly from the way the cool air conditioning of the room hits more of her bare skin and partly from the way Adora is staring at her like she'll never get enough of her. And it makes Catra a little braver.

"Can I take this off?" she asks, pulling on the open ends of Adora's button-up, and Adora nodding before pressing her mouth back to Catra's with an "mmph."

The shirt comes off, and Catra takes the opportunity to run her hands over the planes of Adora's bare stomach. Catra keeps walking Adora backward until the backs of her knees hit the mattress, keeping their lips connected until Adora pulls back and sits on the bed, staring up at Catra almost reverently.

Adora tugs on her hand, and all the doubts in Catra's mind go quiet for awhile while she focuses on only on the way Adora makes her feel.

She's not sure how much time has passed by the time they finally settle into bed together—exhausted but in a much more pleasant way—Catra with her head resting on Adora's chest and listening to the slowing staccato of her heartbeat while Adora traces patterns up and down Catra's arm with her fingers.

"Shame we wasted the last four years when we could have been doing that," Adora says, Catra feeling the vibrations of her voice against her cheek where her head lays.

It turns Catra on all over again just thinking about it, about the way Adora had focused on pressing her lips to every inch of skin she could, how Catra's hand tangled in Adora's hair as she kept kissing lower and causing Catra's hips to buck up toward her face.

"Maybe it's not the worst thing in the world that we had some time apart."

"As long as we come back together in the end."

Catra lifts her head up and cocks an eyebrow, and in an over-the-top sultry voice, leans in and says, "Oh, I'll show you coming together"—

Adora laughs so hard she actually snorts and nearly pushes Catra off the bed.

"That was *such* a bad joke," Adora groans.

"Come on, you like me."

"What happened to this is not because I like you?"

Catra kisses her quickly before answering.

"Oh, I still don't like you. But *you* like *me*."

Adora feigns a shocked, betrayed look before it quickly morphs into a big smile again, and Catra is trying to commit that exact look to memory and figure out every possible way she can make Adora look at her like that.

"Yeah, I really do."

Catra lets herself believe it, propping herself up on her elbow and looking down at Adora, whose head still rests comfortably on her pillow.

"Maybe I like you too, princess."

"Softie."

Catra smiles down at her, soaking up the way Adora looks like this, with her hair fanned out on the pillow (the ponytail and hair poof ditched much earlier in the evening), before sighing and leaning down again, tucking her face into Adora's neck.

Everything is quiet, here in Adora's arms.

And Catra knows it isn't going to stay that way. She knows what's probably going to happen is tomorrow morning she'll wake up and have the urge to overthink and overanalyze everything that's happened, picking it apart until her mind finds some fault or some way she could get hurt.

But Catra feels a little more prepared to handle that when it comes.

She feels Adora stirring underneath her after a few more minutes of quiet.

"I guess I should probably go. Early morning for me tomorrow ."

But she really doesn't want Adora to go.

"I mean, early morning for me too. And we're going to the same place," Catra replies.

"We are," Adora answers thoughtfully .

Keeping her face tucked into Adora's neck, Catra finally asks Adora to stay.

"You could stay, if you wanted."

Adora presses her lips to Catra's forehead, and she feels the way they curl up into a smile against her.

"Yeah, I can stay ," Adora whispers.

///

(SATURDAY EVENING)

Adora can't remember the last time she slept so soundly .

She'd woken up with her arms wrapped around Catra's waist, her back pressed into Adora's front, the low rumble of Catra's purring wanting to lull Adora right back to sleep. She's still a little shocked that they've made it this far , finally breaking out of the terrible prison of Adora's overthinking and Catra's mistrust in any good thing that comes her way.

Adora had left Catra's hotel room early that morning after a few lazy, sleepy kisses and the promise of a repeat performance of the previous night.

And now it's Derby day, just a few hours before the race, and Adora has been running around all day, focused on her work but with Catra's striking eyes in the back of her mind all throughout.

It's getting harder to pay full attention to the tasks at hand, but thankfully, Catra and Melog are next on Adora's list of people and horses to see. When she arrives, Catra's pacing back and forth in front of Melog's stall, and the horse is pawing at the ground, tossing his head up in defiance like he's pretending the box stall is actually a starting gate.

"Hey!"

Catra stops in her tracks when she hears Adora call out, and Melog stops too, head up and ears cocked forward in Adora's direction.

"Adora, hi."

Adora's not really sure what she should do—kiss Catra? Hug her? Awkwardly wave? Give her a handshake? She can tell Catra's on edge (and who wouldn't be, just two hours before such a big event), so she stands back and waits for Catra.

"Here for another drug test?" Catra jokes.

A bit of the tension seems to roll off Catra, and Adora takes a step closer.

"Lonnie's already on it. I was actually hoping to run into you."

Catra smiles up at Adora and asks, "And why would you need to see me?"

Admittedly, Adora's stomach has been twisting in knots of anxiety all day, worried about whether or not seeing Catra again would be

awkward. She's not entirely sure how to handle a "hey we were best friends for four years and then shit happened, and now we're good again and being honest but also we just slept together" situation.

But she's a little relieved to see that Catra's bringing a light, flirtatious tone to the conversation.

"Gotta wish you luck. Only a couple of hours until post time."

Catra turns toward Melog and offers him a hand to sniff before he lowers his head and lets Catra scratch behind his ears.

"Walk over to the paddock is in an hour. Isn't it, buddy?"

Adora takes another step forward and does the same, letting Melog sniff at her hand before poking a finger against his velvet nose.

She watches the way Catra melts into Melog and vice-versa, how the horse leans into her touch, and his eyelids start to droop closed as Catra cards her fingers through his forelock.

"He really mirrors you, you know ," Adora observes.

"What? No, he doesn't."

But it's something Adora's noticed for a long time, since they started working at Fright Zone together . Catra's always had an understanding of horses that Adora's been envious of. Not that Adora doesn't get along well with the animals, but Catra..she just seems to get them on a deeper level.

And they seem to recognize that in return.

It's no wonder that Catra is here, rapidly rising to the top of the game, when she has such a deep connection with Melog. With all the horses, really.

"They all do. You're very connected to all of them."

Catra shrugs and continues down Melog's neck, massaging the muscles of his shoulder.

"They're emotionally intuitive creatures."

Melog pokes his nose toward Adora's pocket, begging for a treat.

"Especially this guy," Catra adds, patting his neck and handing Adora a small carrot to feed Melog.

The horse greedily takes it from Adora's outstretched hand and keeps rooting around for another, disappointed to find that when he licks Adora's hand, there's nothing there.

She pulls her hand away and falls silent for a few moments, letting Catra relax into the feel of being close to Melog before she finally asks, "How are you?"

"I'm fine," Catra responds, shrugging and looking away from Adora, instead keeping her attention firmly fixed on scratching Melog.

"Catra—"

She knows Catra's lying. She can tell by the way Melog tenses up, and the way Catra grips the horse's mane when Adora asks.

"I'm freaking out a little."

Catra doesn't look at her, just keeps her hand clenched in the mane on Melog's neck, staring at her own hand.

"I just really don't want to spend the next several hours with Shadow Weaver and Hordak."

Adora can see the way Catra's jaw clenches after she says it, nearly hears the way her teeth click and grit together nervously. She doesn't want that for Catra either, especially if the outcome happens to be anything less than a win.

And, if Melog does win, Adora can't help but be selfish and want to be there with Catra to share those moments where he crosses under the wire first.

"So don't."

"Adora, I—"

"Watch it with me," Adora explains. "I'll be right down near the track. We can watch it together."

Catra finally looks over at her, clearly unsure of the proposal.

"Adora—"

"Maybe Bow and Glimmer want to join us."

Catra looks away again, and she's not sure if she's pushed too far or said the wrong thing because Catra doesn't say anything at first. She just keeps petting Melog, the look on her face unreadable.

"Yes, I'm sure Shadow Weaver would love to know that not only am I hanging out with you, but I'm also fraternizing with the competition."

Fuck Shadow Weaver, Adora wants to say, but she's not sure that would be the most helpful.

Truthfully, she's just excited, and she wants to spend time with Catra and wants to be there for her. And the thought of getting to do that with their other friends too…

Adora just can't help but want more.

"Well, I'll be in the paddock the whole time. Come find me if you want. I'll pass the message along to Bow and Glimmer too."

Catra watches Adora with her head tilted, like she's considering it.

"Whatever you choose though," Adora adds, "I hope it's you and me together in the winners' circle."

The callback to the first day they met makes Catra smile, but only briefly, before she answers, "Don't you have to be there anyway? Like in case something goes wrong?"

She likes Catra a lot—she really, really does. But her habit of deflecting when Adora tries to say something kind or be sweet is a killer sometimes.

Adora groans and steps toward Catra, wanting to reach out and hold her by the shoulders but pulling her arms back before she does.

"Just let me say nice things, please."

Catra walks away from Melog and toward Adora, and she barely has time to react before Catra is pulling her in and kissing her, quickly nipping at Adora's bottom lip before pulling back again.

Adora wonders if she's ever going to get used to the feeling of Catra's lips on hers.

"What was that for?"

"Good luck, I hope," Catra says, busying herself by neatly arranging all of Melog's tack—the saddle, the bridle, the pink saddlecloth with the number eight on it.

"You kiss all the track vets for good luck?"

"Of course. Duh. Hope is hot," Catra deadpans.

"Please dont say that about my boss."

Catra continues working around Melog, reaching for his leg wraps and sweeping any excess dirt off them before she moves to unclip Melog's stall door and walk in next to him. It's about time for Catra to start preparing, and Adora knows she probably needs to go.

"Bye, Adora," Catra calls out, and Adora can only hope that she sees her next in the paddock.

She does see Catra next in the paddock, because at the very least, Melog has to pass through there on the way to the track, and Adora is standing by with D . Hope in the event of any accidents.

Shadow Weaver and Hordak are hovering in the center of the paddock on the grassy patch where all the owners congregate. Where other owners are speaking to each other and laughing, clinking glasses together and enjoying themselves, Hordak and Shadow Weaver are watching Catra like they're just waiting for her to mess up.

But Catra doesn't falter . Adora watches how she focuses intently on giving her final directions to Kyle as he nervously adjusts the Fright Zone Farm silks on his body , clipping his helmet closed and tightening it. Catra doesn't waver as she expertly places the saddlecloth, pad, and saddle on Melog's back, tightening the girth and making sure it's in its proper place.

It's only once the call of "Riders Up!" comes, and Catra is helping Kyle get a leg up on Melog, that Adora notices her taking a glance at the grandstand, at all the people, the horses, the decorations and flowers that light up the track.

Lonnie and Scorpia are walking on either side of Melog as he joins the parade around the stone walking path of the paddock, Catra giving him one last pat on the shoulder and whispering something under her breath that only the horse can probably hear.

And Adora's heart swells with pride as she watches Catra, still keeping her eyes trained on Melog, as he exits the paddock and heads out under the shadow of the grandstand, tucked into his place in the parade of twenty horses.

She watches as Shadow Weaver and Hordak approach her, and Adora notices the way Catra tenses up immediately as she says

something to the two of them before they exchange glances, turn back to Catra, and frown, before turning on their heels and walking out of the paddock, up a staircase that will likely lead them to their seats.

And Catra stays put, stock-still in the middle of the paddock, staring up at the same screen that Adora plans to watch the race on.

Adora only turns away to watch Angella and Micah wrapping Glimmer and Bow up in a hug before her two friends walk over to her. She barely has time to greet the couple before she hears someone clear their throat behind her.

"Room for one more?"

Catra.

"Hey , Catra."

Catra lets out a shaky breath, fidgeting with Melog's halter in her hands that she'd replaced with the bit and bridle.

"Hey , Adora," she answers, quietly enough that only Adora can hear the edge of anxiety in her voice.

Meanwhile, Bow can barely hold in his excitement, grinning as he looks back and forth between the two of them.

"Well, look at you two getting along."

"Shut up," Catra shoots back, punching him in the shoulder .

"Easy , Horde Scum," Glimmer adds with a smirk.

Catra smirks right back, and then holds out a hand for Glimmer to shake. She takes it.

"Good luck to your horse, Sparkles."

"Back at ya."

And even though Catra looks like she's on the edge of panic, and she really needs to focus on that, Adora can't help but smile at the way she interacts with Bow. It's been so long since the three of them have been together like this, and then to have the addition of a friend like Glimmer too. And on top of all of that, to have this all of this happening in a place where they'd always dreamed of ending up—

It feels so surreal.

And Adora is *so damn proud* of Catra. She turns toward her again, stepping away from Bow and Glimmer and maneuvering them so Adora's back is facing their friends, covering Catra's face from them as Bow and Glimmer stare up at the screen.

"How are you feeling?"

Catra sets the halter on the ground and slips her hand into Adora's, squeezing tightly and looking up at the screen in time to see Melog being led into the starting gate.

"Just want him to come back safe."

Adora presses a kiss to Catra's forehead and hears her let out a heavy sigh. The unspoken *he will* sits heavy between them—because it's not a guarantee in a race this chaotic—but then Catra and Adora are turning fully to face the screen and watch the race together.

Seconds later, Catra's hand squeezes Adora's even tighter when the gates clang open and the track announcer's voice booms over the sound system, yelling, "And they're off!"

Adora hears Glimmer and Bow muttering words of encouragement to Swift Wind, who races toward the front, the bright white of his coat standing out against most of the other horses on the track. Melog's

broken cleanly as well, key urging him up and inside to avoid losing ground on the first turn.

The stampede of horses charges around the corner and along the backstretch, tight quarters already causing some to lose their position quickly and drop back or have their jockeys tug on the reins to avoid clipping heels. But Melog is three-wide just behind Swift Wind, who leads, and another horse named Mint Julep. Adora hears Catra groan as she watches Key still pushing Melog along, trying to get him closer to the front and within a half-length of Swift Wind.

"Don't push him too much too early," she hears Catra mutter, and Adora feels the grip on her hand tighten once again as the horses race on.

They're more than halfway home, and Melog is hanging with the two frontrunners but doesn't seem to be moving as easily as the others who lead him. Key is still after him, shaking the reins and giving him more encouragement as they start to round the far turn.

Adora hears Catra whisper "fuck," and must assume that as soon as they round the turn for home, Melog will drop back, and the closers will start to overtake them all down the stretch.

Next to Catra and Adora, Glimmer and Bow are yelling loudly as Swift Wind takes them into the homestretch with a scant lead over Mint Julep.

But as they come out of the turn, and Key starts to tap Melog with the whip, something Catra (and even Adora) doesn't expect happens.

Melog doesn't drop back.

He doesn't give in.

He rounds off the turn, puts his head down, and starts sprinting toward the finish line with a second wind.

Catra is yelling as Mint Julep starts to fall behind into the gap between the three leaders and the rest of the field. They're too far ahead for any of the closers to catch them. Swift Wind is still on the rail with a neck in front of Melog, but Kyle keeps urging him forward frantically. And Melog keeps lengthening his stride, pushing harder and harder until his nose is in front.

Adora's so focused on the finish that she doesn't even register that Catra has let go of her hand and has both arms in the air, screaming for Melog to keep going while the thundering roar of the rest of the crowd pales in comparison to the sound of Catra's voice.

Melog crosses the finish line first, Swift Wind at his heels in second, and the rest of the field long forgotten.

"Oh my god," Catra murmurs, voice hoarse and dropped to a whisper, mouth dropped open in shock as she stares up at the screen that shows Kyle pumping a fist in victory as Melog gallops out and starts to slow down safely, the outrider meeting them to escort them toward the winners' circle.

Melog won.

Catra won.

Adora can't stop the tears that bubble up suddenly, a sob escaping her as it hits her that *Catra did it.*

She won, and Adora gets to be here with her, and she's not entirely sure that any of this is real, but—

"He did it. I did it. Oh my god."

Catra crushes Adora in a hug, and she quickly feels Bow and Glimmer jump in as well, Glimmer even placing a kiss on Catra's cheek with a noisy, "Mwah!"

Catra starts giggling uncontrollably as cameras start to point toward them, realizing that the most exciting and heartwarming celebration is not in Hordak and Shadow Weaver's boxseats, but here in the paddock as a group of old friends realize a dream that's been years in the making.

But the best part of living this dream with her friends right next to her is that it doesn't end here.

It's just the beginning.

The beginning of Adora's career, of Catra's well-deserved rise to becoming a top trainer and out of the shadows of Weaver and Hordak, of Bow and Glimmer's relationship.

The beginning for Catra and Adora, too.

Adora doesn't quite know where they stand or what comes next, but she's here with Catra now.

And that's so much more than she ever thought she'd have.

Catra won't let go of her , crying into Adora's shoulder, and Adora lifts her and spins her around. When she sets her back down, she pulls back just enough to get Catra to look at her .

"What did I tell you? You and me together in the winners' circle."

Catra smiles, laughing while she cries more happy tears, and pulls Adora in for a kiss, not caring if the cameras catch it for the whole audience to see.

"It's always been you and me, princess."

Yeah, Adora thinks.

Yeah, it has.

Chapter End Notes

sometimes love is stored in the emotionally intuitive horse!and in adora's biceps. and in bow's friendship. anyway, please comment and kudos and come bother me on twitter here. knowing me, i'll probably write a bonus scene or two somewhere down the line so if that's something you all would be interested in, please let me know!

thanks again for reading. i had a lot of fun with this fic and bringing some of my own interests into it.

the barn

Chapter Summary

> a few months after the derby, catra finally makes good on her promise of "maybe another time."
>
> almost called this "five times they didn't fuck in a barn and one time they did."

Chapter Notes

> well..... this happened.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There are several benefits to dating Adora, Catra finds out very quickly.

One of them is that, even though Catra insists on keeping their professional lives as separate as possible, she now has a renowned equine vet around all the time in case of emergency. Adora's helped Catra get Melog on better supplements and a better workout regimen, not even because he's now worth millions of dollars after his Etherian Derby win (and subsequent wins that made him a Triple Crown winner). It's simply because Adora loves Melog almost as much as Catra does.

Another benefit is Adora's wardrobe. Though they're a little bit loose on her smaller frame, Catra can't help but steal Adora's hoodies or wear her flannels around her apartment as a reminder of her girlfriend while she's away. Adora has even tried to get Catra to wear that annoying, old red jacket of hers at times, but Catra declines every time.

(Although, she really should just say she'll wear it sometime and then "accidentally" lose it.)

But one of Catra's favorite perks of dating Adora is that years of sexual tension and pining have somehow lived up to the hype. Adora's hands, lips, teeth, tongue—Catra's still not entirely sure that this isn't all some elaborate daydream she's going to wake up from. But from the way Adora still watches her with darkening gray-blue eyes and pulls her in roughly when they're alone at night in Catra's bedroom to the gentle giggle that bubbles up from Adora's throat when they're out in public and laughing at something Bow just said, Catra finds that she just can't get enough of Adora.

At this point, Glimmer and Bow have learned to roll their eyes and look away from the way Catra and Adora have the tendency to go overboard with their public displays of affection. The innocent hand-holding or Catra flopping into Adora's lap on the couch of Glimmer and Adora's apartment has gotten a little out of control once or twice (but to be fair, Glimmer and Bow weren't in the room either time, and Adora's lips were *right there*).

And right now, in the darkness of the dance floor, only multi-colored lights reflecting on the walls of the large tent that Bright Moon Stables has set up on their property, Catra and Adora can enjoy a little more privacy despite being in a crowded room. Right now, Catra can wrap her arms around Adora's shoulders and wait for Adora to pull her closer by the hips, wait for Adora to lean forward and kiss her.

Their friends are somewhere else in the room, but honestly, Catra lost track of them about ten minutes ago when yet another stranger approached Glimmer and complimented her and her family on what a lovely party they'd thrown. It was around that same time that Catra found herself growing bored of fielding congratulations on Melog's continued success and wanting to pull Adora into the crowd.

And while Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist and pulls her a little closer, smiling down at her with a wide grin that tells Catra she's just bordering on tipsy, Adora doesn't lean in to kiss her. Instead, she closes the space between their faces but tilts her head to the left to whisper in Catra's ear.

"I remember us being in a very similar situation a few months ago."

Catra holds Adora in place, cheek-to-cheek with her now, as she smirks, remembering the Derby Week party from a few months prior. Catra remembers the way she'd stared Adora down while she danced with someone else, just daring her to approach, remembers the way Adora cut in and Catra couldn't help but call her out on the jealous look on her face. She remembers the way Adora's forehead pressed into her neck while Catra felt the heat of Adora's body all over her back.

But Catra whispers back coyly, "Not sure I remember what you mean. Remind me?"

Adora pulls back suddenly and narrows her eyes at Catra. Then, a flicker of…*something* in Adora's eyes. Catra's not sure if Adora's turned on, has something mischievous planned, or a combination of the two, but suddenly, she's being whirled around in Adora's arms until her girlfriend is grabbing her by the hips and pulling Catra back against her front.

Catra hopes that Adora can't hear the gasp that escapes past her lips over the sound of the music but knows she's probably close enough that Adora heard, feels the way her fingers tighten on Catra's hips after she gasps.

Adora leans in to whisper in Catra's ear again, this time from behind her. "You don't remember pressing your ass up against me like you knew exactly what it would do to me?"

And *god*, Adora drives her crazy when she's like this. The teasing, the lead-up, the banter…

"Oh, *that*?"

It just never gets old.

"You were such a tease."

Catra sways her hips in time to the beat of the song that plays, circling them back into Adora and reveling in the way she moans while Catra snakes a hand up behind her, gently scratching her fingertips against Adora's neck and then up into her hair.

"Still am, *Dr. Grayskull*," Catra utters, the words rumbling out of her mouth low and throaty in a way she knows makes Adora's heart beat faster.

Again, Catra holds Adora's head in place, still pressed close enough to her that she can feel Adora's shaky breaths against the shell of her ear while Catra keeps grinding back into Adora.

"Sure wish that night would have gone a little dif ferently," Adora whispers breathlessly.

Catra slides one hand down to rest over one of Adora's on her hip, Catra lacing her fingers into the spaces between Adora's. Catra taps her index finger against Adora's, like she's trying to keep her grounded to the present before they completely lose themselves in this haze.

"Tell me what you had in mind, then."

Though Catra will admit, she's probably not helping matters by asking Adora to list off all the things she wanted to do to her that night.

But then again, she really can't help herself. She loves Adora talking to her like this, holding her like this, touching her like this.

"Well, for starters, I had my hands here," Adora begins, her hands skimming along the seam of Catra's jeans and up further, this time unable to reach bare skin from the way Catra's button-up is tucked into her jeans.

Catra almost pulls on the fabric herself. She almost tugs it so it springs loose, and Adora can put her hands on her however she

wants. But then Adora is sliding her fingertips over Catra's forearms, one following the arm that now hangs limply at her side and the other following the trail up to the hand in Adora's hair.

"And you had yours here," Adora continues.

Catra's completely losing the beat of the song, her hips jerking out of sync with the bass when Adora's knuckles brush against her sides as her hands slide back down to rest on her hips.

"And if I were a little braver that night, I would have done this."

The music in the background of the party is completely lost to Catra. The only song she can focus on is the lilt in Adora's voice before she leans down and presses her lips against Catra's neck.

"Adora—"

Her hips are fully rocking back into Adora, no longer in time to the tempo of the music but arching into Adora every time she pulls back before kissing her again, never wanting to lose the feel of Adora's soft lips against her skin. Rocking into Adora, who holds her steady and starts a trail of open-mouthed kisses up to Catra's jawline, alternating between gentle nips against her skin and biting down and sucking the muscle of Catra's neck into her mouth in a way that she knows is going to leave a bruise and makes Catra moan a little too loudly for a public place.

Fuck. Right. They're still in a public place.

"People are gonna see us, Adora," Catra grits out, her hand still tangled in Adora's hair as she keeps mapping the line of Catra's neck and jaw with her lips.

She groans against Catra's neck, reluctantly pulling back and then quickly pressing one last kiss against Catra's cheek.

"Well, that brings me to the next part."

Adora takes one hand and loosens Catra's grip on her hair, and Catra just lets her. She's completely strung out on the feeling of Adora's lips on her skin, and she's not entirely sure she can stand up straight if she tried.

Thankfully, Adora does the work for her, turning Catra in her arms once more until they're face to face again, Catra leaning into her and looping her arms around Adora's shoulders once more. Adora's staring down at her, eyes much darker now and strobe lights reflecting in her pupils. Catra follows her gaze down to her own neck, where Adora is no doubt surveying the marks she's left.

Then, Adora's gaze flickers back up to Catra's. There's a fire in her eyes that matches the cocky grin she sports when she whispers, "Then I would have asked if you wanted to get out of here."

Catra's in a daze, staring down at Adora's lips and thinking about how badly she wants to kiss her until she's out of breath.

"Yes," Catra hears herself mumble.

Catra's eyes widen, realizing what she's just said, and she looks up at Adora, who's looking back at her with eyes just as wide as Catra's feel, and are they really just going to ditch this party?

"Do you do you really want to?" Adora asks, fumbling over the words and suddenly seeming unsure if she's pushed a little too far.

But Catra doesn't let herself overthink it, doesn't let *Adora* overthink it. She grabs Adora by the collar of that stupid red jacket (which she for some reason *insisted* on wearing to a party in the middle of the hot, humid Bright Moon *summer*) and heads directly for the nearest opening in the tent, pulling Adora behind her and ignoring any stares she gets from other patrons of the event.

When they get outside, Catra drops her hand from Adora's jacket, peering around to see the fountain in the front drive where they were interrupted by Scorpia the last time they were here, the makeshift

parking lot just beyond that, the Bright Moon front office over to the right, and—

Hmm.

If Catra remembers the layout of this place correctly, she knows exactly where they can go.

Catra whirls around to face Adora, this time grabbing her by the collar with both hands, pressing her lips against Adora's and pulling her closer, just for a moment, just to momentarily satisfy the urge to do so that's been playing in her mind since they stepped out onto the dance floor.

She smirks when she pulls back, Adora's eyes still half-lidded and mouth still fallen open, before Catra catches her by the hand and pulls Adora past the tent. If she knows where she's going, it shouldn't be far from here—

"Where are we going?" Adora asks.

"Two fantasies for the price of one tonight, princess."

Catra tosses a wink over her shoulder and laughs at Adora, who's clearly going through the mental list of sex fantasies she's shared with Catra over the last few months and trying to figure out which one she's trying to fulfill.

"What are you"—

But before Adora can finish her sentence, Catra sees it just a few yards in front of them, only lit up outside by one spotlight over the entrance.

"Oh."

Before them, in the dim lighting of the single spotlight, is a barn that Catra knows from her past experiences at Bright Moon parties is

abandoned and quiet. She knows because she's been to one of these parties before, had hid from Adora in this very barn a year ago.

But Catra figures she'll leave that part out for now as she pulls on Adora's hand again, and Adora follows willingly.

Catra pushes on the edge of the barn door, and sure enough, it rolls to the side just enough that Catra and Adora can wedge through. The dim light outside allows Catra to see well enough to find four light switches on the inside wall. Catra flicks one and watches and listens as an old overhead light flickers and buzzes, covering just a few stalls in enough light for them to see.

"Are you sure—"

"It's an empty barn. No one's going to come looking for us here."

Catra watches as Adora looks around for a moment, then shrugs and nods toward one of the open stalls. Catra grins, pulling Adora closer and letting any lingering sounds from the party fall quiet, focused only on the sounds of Adora's lips pulling and pushing against hers, the sounds of Adora moaning when Catra's tongue darts out to run along Adora's bottom lip, the sounds of the wooden barn creaking as Adora presses her against the wall.

She pulls away from Adora's lips to start kissing her jawline before nipping at the bottom of Adora's earlobe and whispering, "If you make any puns about riding during this, you are walking home. Understood?"

Adora laughs so hard she snorts and quips, "So if I say being here with you brings me unbridled joy?..."

Catra throws her head back with a groan (but *god*, she loves this woman so much) before burying her head in Adora's shoulder and mumbling into it, "You are so fucking cheesy."

Adora's fingernails gently scratch up and down her back as she plants a kiss on the top of Catra's head.

"You love me."

Catra pulls back and rolls her eyes.

"Shut up."

"That's *so* embarrassing for you," Adora teases.

"You've literally been in love with me for how long?" Catra shoots back, remembering Adora's confession at the fountain that Catra swears she can hear in the distance.

But Adora cuts off any further conversation by kissing Catra again, her fingers searching to separate the buttons of her shirt from their holds.

"Shhh, I'm busy trying to take your shirt off," Adora mumbles against Catra's lips.

So Catra goes quiet after that, focusing on the feeling of Adora's lips on hers, of the warm summer air hitting her skin with every button Adora pops open until her shirt is barely hanging off her shoulders, and Adora pulls back to stare at Catra's exposed chest and stomach.

"You're so gorgeous."

Catra's not sure she'll ever get used to the reverent way Adora calls her beautiful, the genuine surprise in her voice every time she sees Catra like this, like she's taking it all in again for the first time. And she'll definitely never get used to the way Adora peppers kisses along her collarbone and starts heading further south.

"And *you* are driving me crazy kissing me like that."

"Oh yeah?" Adora mumbles against her chest, Catra trying to shift closer to Adora's lips and trying to get her to *just shut up already.*

"Yeah," Catra sighs.

Adora keeps trailing her lips down Catra's body to the tops of her breasts and back up. She doesn't even bother telling Adora to take her bra off, or even for her to take Catra's pants off. She opens the button of her jeans herself and pulls on Adora's head, still kissing along her chest, and connects their lips as Catra arches into her.

Adora's learned enough about Catra's body language to know that this is as close to begging as Catra's going to get for now, arching into her and kissing her fiercely like this. She's learned enough about Catra to know that this is her way of saying *I need you* without words.

Catra feels Adora smile against her lips when she reaches a hand down to find her jeans unbuttoned and the zipper pulled down already, just waiting impatiently for Adora's hand. Adora's fingers trail down her stomach, and Catra rolls her hips against the space between them, desperate for friction and already way too close to the edge.

(And really, Catra would be embarrassed if she didn't find the whole thing so fucking hot.)

"Will you fucking touch me already?" Catra snaps when Adora's hand decides to slide past the opening of her jeans and away from it to squeeze Catra's ass.

She feels more than hears the throaty laugh Adora lets out as she keeps kissing Catra, a little more urgent and eager now as Catra's nails claw at Adora's back, trying to pull her closer still and trying to convince Adora to just *put her fucking hand where Catra wants it already.*

Adora doesn't keep her waiting anymore, sliding her fingers down the front of Catra's pants, both of them groaning when Adora's fingers meet the slick heat of Catra's folds, and Adora obeying immediately when Catra whines, "Inside."

She wraps a leg around Adora's waist, wanting to be closer still, as Adora's fingers press deeper inside her. Catra barely remembers that they're at a party, in a barn, and the only sounds she can hear anymore are her own high-pitched gasps and the filthy things Adora is whispering in her ear as she fucks her.

Catra grips onto Adora tighter as she comes, knees suddenly wobbling and just wanting to hold Adora close to her for as long as she can.

Catra thinks that maybe the biggest perk of dating Adora is the way she holds her~~its~~ with that same gentle strength that Adora threads throughout so many parts of her life.

Adora slides her fingers out of Catra, causing her to shudder from the aftershocks, but she uses her now free arm to wrap around Catra.

And Catra melts into the embrace.

"We should go home," Adora whispers into Catra's shoulder.

Catra's not sure she's ever heard such a great idea in her life. Because as great as this is, Catra cant wait to get her hands on Adora back in her own bed.

"Especially with how loud you can be," Catra responds.

"Hey"—

She pulls back and smiles at Adora's affronted look, then leans forward to quickly press another kiss to Adora's lips.

"Love you."

And Adora smiles, finally letting go of Catra to let her button her shirt up and zip up her pants.

"Let's get out of here," she says, offering a hand to Catra once she's finally (somewhat) re-settled.

(Though they're going to have to make a quiet exit, because Catra knows that her hair is probably a mess, her neck is full of marks, and her face is undoubtedly still flushed.)

Catra takes her hand and bumps her shoulder against Adora's.

"Gonna let me ride you?"

Catra feels Adora's hand squeeze against hers tightly, feels Adora's whole body tense up when she says it.

"Catra!" Adora attempts to say it in an admonishing tone, but it just comes out conveying every ounce of sexual frustration that Catra imagines her girlfriend is still feeling. "Weren't you the one who said no puns?"

Catra drops Adora's hand, reaching to turn out of the lights of the barn and walking out into the low light of the single bulb that flickers outside.

She turns around and smirks at Adora, whose face is obscured by the shadows

"Oh, that was a genuine question, Adora."

It's dark outside, but Catra can't miss the way Adora's jaw drops, and definitely doesn't miss the sound of her nearly choking on air when her breath catches.

Chapter End Notes

sooooo....kudos, comments, live tweets?

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